

Market Watch

Fed holds rates; Powell flags inflation concerns

Summary

Event: The Fed held its policy rate at 3.75% for the second straight meeting, as widely expected, while maintaining its projection for one more rate cut in 2026. Fed Chair Powell voiced concern about the slow progress in lowering inflation even before the Middle East conflict erupted, as the central bank revised up its forecasts for inflation and growth for 2026-27. The rate sensitive US two-year government bond yield jumped 10bps to 3.77%, the USD index rose 0.5%, while the S&P500 index slumped 1.4% to a four-month low. Markets are pricing less than 60% chance of a rate cut by end-2026.

Our View: Under our base scenario of a short-lived Middle East conflict, followed by an economic soft-landing, we expect the Fed to hold rates in H1 as it looks through a near-term rise in inflation. We then expect it to cut rates by 50bps in H2 as it focusses on reviving a stagnant job market.

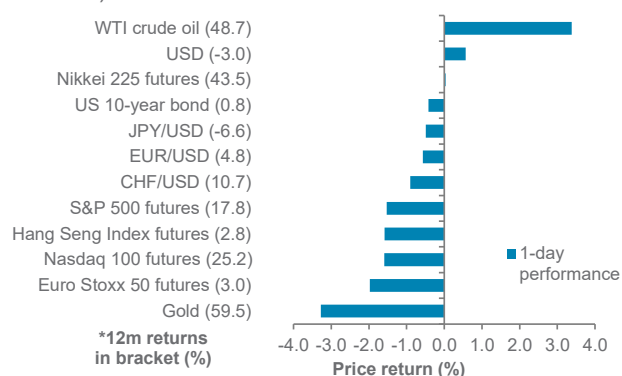
Investment strategy: stay diversified, preference for US assets, hedge against inflation. With the Middle East situation fluid, a diversified allocation with a tilt towards USD assets remains prudent, given the US is likely to be the least impacted from higher oil prices since it's a net oil exporter. US corporate earnings estimates have been revised higher lately, underlining solid fundamentals. US inflation-protected bonds, energy-based currencies (CAD, AUD, NOK) and gold remain key hedges against inflation and geopolitical risks.

Fed's new 'dot plot' projections

Fed lifts growth, inflation projections. The Fed's "dot plot" survey of members' projections showed a median forecast of one 25bps rate cut by end-2026 and one more cut in 2027. It lifted growth and core PCE inflation estimates for 2026 to 2.4% and 2.7% for 2026, respectively. Powell said the Fed is willing to see through a short spike in inflation due to oil prices and prior tariffs as it assesses the impact of the Middle East conflict, provided inflation expectations remain anchored.

The USD rose with bond yields as Fed Chair Powell voiced concerns about inflation as oil prices jumped

1-day asset performance: 17-Mar close to 19-Mar (9AM HKT/SGT)



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

The Fed revised higher its growth and inflation estimates for 2026-27, while maintaining its projection for one rate cut in 2026 and another cut in 2027

Fed's new vs. old economic and policy rate projections

Dates	GDP		Unemployment		Core PCE		Rates estimates	
	Old	New	Old	New	Old	New	Old	New
2026	2.3	2.4	4.4	4.4	2.5	2.7	3.4	3.4
2027	2.0	2.3	4.2	4.3	2.1	2.2	3.1	3.1
2028	1.9	2.1	4.2	4.2	2.0	2.0	3.1	3.1
LR*	1.8	2.0	4.2	4.2			3.0	3.1

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Base scenario

We see 50bps of Fed rate cuts this year. Our base case (60% probability) is that the US economy achieves a soft-landing this year. A short-lived Middle East conflict would temporarily raise US energy costs, hurt real disposable income and spending without causing a sustained inflation shock. Nevertheless, the US is likely to be more resilient than other major economies, given it's the world's largest oil producer and a net oil exporter. Moreover, an estimated USD 160bn of tax refunds in Q1 due to last year's tax cuts should partly offset the hit to household wallets from higher oil prices, sustaining consumption. Also, AI-driven investment is likely to pick up this year, enabling economic growth to settle below long-term trend. Any rollback in tariffs heading into November mid-term elections would provide further support to growth.

There is low risk of a wage spiral, since the US job market was close to stalling before the conflict and is much weaker than during the 2022 energy shock caused by the Ukraine conflict. US consumer sentiment remains near post-pandemic lows, while long-term inflation expectation remains low, although near-term inflation expectations have spiked with oil prices.

Against this backdrop, we expect the Fed to hold rates in H1 as it looks through a brief energy-led inflation upturn. A delay in Fed rate cuts is likely to put further downward pressure on the job market. This, in turn, is likely to push the central bank, under incoming Chair Kevin Warsh (subject to Senate confirmation), to turn dovish in H2 as oil price-driven inflation fades and the focus turns to reviving the weak job market. We expect the Fed to deliver 50bps of cuts in H2 vs. market expectations of a 25bps cut.

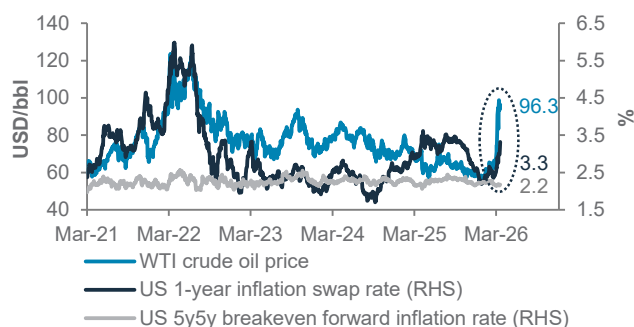
Downside and upside risk scenarios

There is a rising risk (25% probability) of a hard landing in the US economy, especially with the start of the Middle East conflict. A prolonged conflict would keep oil prices higher for longer, delaying Fed rate cuts and further impairing the US job market. A stock market downturn hurting investor confidence, or a bond market sell-off on inflation concerns and/or debt concerns are other tail risks.

On the upside, we assign 15% probability to a scenario that US tax and Fed rate cuts, against the backdrop of fiscal easing in Germany and China, and a potential rollback of US tariffs could revive "animal spirits", provided the Middle East conflict is short-lived. A Russia-Ukraine peace deal, a US-China "grand bargain" or EU-wide defence spending could potentially lift global growth prospects, improving the outlook for US exports.

US short-term inflation expectations have risen with the surge in oil prices, but long-term inflation expectations remain subdued

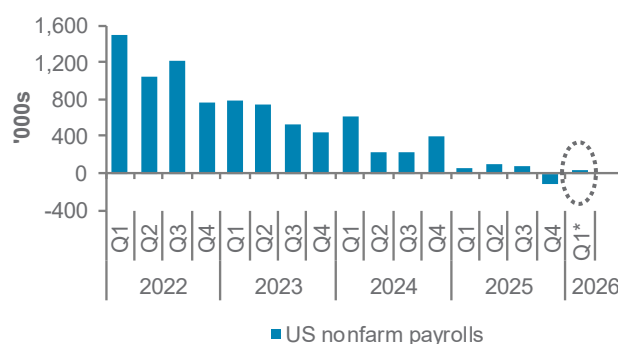
WTI crude oil price, 1-year and 5-year market-based inflation expectations



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

US job creation had virtually stalled before the start of the Middle East conflict; we expect the Fed to cut rates by 50bps in H2 to revive the flagging job market

US quarterly net job creation



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered; Q1 2026 reflects January and February net nonfarm payrolls

What does this mean for investors?

Stay diversified, with a US tilt: A diversified allocation, with a tilt towards US assets remains justified, given heightened Middle East risks. The US economy is likely to be relatively less impacted from the conflict, compared with Europe and Asia, given its limited exposure to Middle East energy sources, significantly reduced energy intensity (US oil consumption per unit of real GDP has fallen by almost 70% since 1980) and because it is a net oil exporter.

US equity valuations turn attractive. US corporate earnings estimates have been revised higher in recent weeks, despite the pullback in equities due to the Middle East conflict. This has made US equity valuations more attractive, especially if the conflict proves short-lived (our base case) and oil prices fall back towards USD 70-80/bbl. The robust US earnings outlook is led by the tech-sector which is benefitting from structurally strong AI-related investments.

Maintain inflation hedges: US energy equities and inflation-protected bonds remain key hedges against an oil-led inflation spike. Although gold has pulled back from near-record highs in recent weeks amid USD strength, history shows it is one of the best hedges against stagflation risks. We have a 6% allocation to gold in our balanced allocation. Oil and commodity-based currencies such as CAD, NOK and AUD are likely to benefit, while Asian oil importer currencies are likely to remain under pressure in the short term.

Await opportunity to lock in bond yields. The negative growth impact of higher oil prices is limiting how high bond yields can rise. Any sign of the conflict ending would likely lead to a pullback in US bond yields and the USD. In that scenario, markets are likely to refocus on expected policy divergence, with the Fed cutting rates later this year to support a flagging job market, while other central banks hold (ECB) or hike (BoJ, RBA) rates. We expect the USD index (DXY) to end the year around 96, almost 4% weaker than today, while the US 10-year government bond falls towards 3.75-4.0% range.

Next focus: Apart from Middle East developments and the shape of the oil price curve, US jobless claims and inflation expectation indicators will be closely watched for the initial impact of the conflict.

The US job market has been fragile since Q4 last year – any signs of cracks would likely bring forward expectations of Fed rate cuts. Conversely, a rise in long-term inflation expectations in the event of a prolonged shutdown of the Hormuz strait would revive rate hike expectations, especially given the Fed's experience of falling behind curve in the aftermath of the Ukraine conflict in 2022.

— **Rajat Bhattacharya**, Senior Investment Strategist

The USD and US bond yields have risen amid rising near-term inflation expectations; we expect USD and bond yields to fall back as growth concerns return

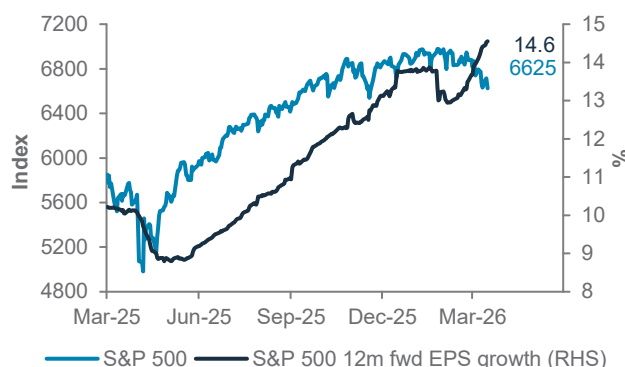
USD index (DXY) and US 10y, 30y government bond yields



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

US equity valuations have turned attractive as stocks have declined in recent weeks, despite a rebound in earnings growth estimates

S&P500 and 12-month forward EPS growth



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

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Market Watch

Enduring FX Characteristics in Volatile Markets

Summary

Event: Recent bouts of market turbulence have underscored the crucial role of strategic currency management within clients' portfolios. This foreign exchange (FX) playbook aims to provide enduring perspectives on the structural features that define major currency groupings, offering a framework to contextualise recent volatility and inform resilient FX positioning. Our focus is on the lasting traits that underpin the behaviour of safe-haven and commodity currencies.

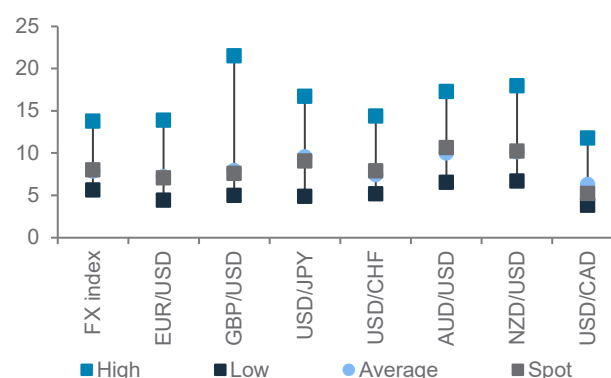
Safe-Haven Currencies: CHF, JPY, and USD

The Swiss franc (CHF), Japanese yen (JPY) and US dollar (USD) are widely recognised as the world's pre-eminent safe-haven currencies. Their status is rooted in a combination of i) high liquidity, ii) global reserve currency roles and iii) robust capital flow dynamics.

- **Liquidity and Market Depth:** All three currencies benefit from highly liquid financial markets and deep pools of capital. The USD, in particular, underpins the vast majority of global trade and financial transactions, ensuring ready access and minimal transaction costs even during periods of stress.
- **Reserve Status:** The USD remains the dominant global reserve currency, held by central banks worldwide as a store of value and a tool for stabilising local economies. The CHF and JPY, while smaller in scale, are also favoured for their perceived stability, with the former benefiting from Switzerland's reputation for prudent fiscal management.
- **Capital Flows & Economic Fundamentals:** In times of uncertainty, investors seek refuge in currencies backed by strong institutional frameworks and stable inflation and political environments. The Swiss and Japanese economies are renowned for their current account surpluses and conservative policy settings, while the US

FX volatility range varies yet wide

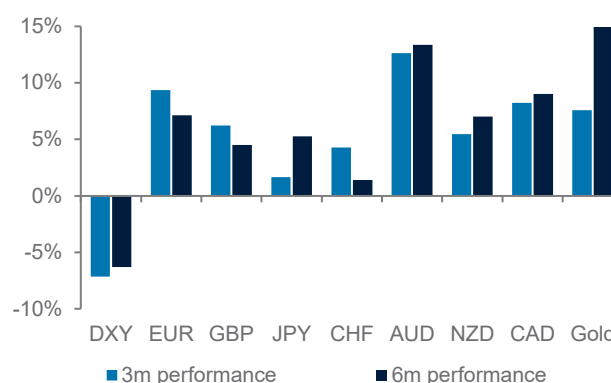
Major currencies' volatility range



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

During the 2003 Iraq conflict, major currencies rose but USD fell

Major currencies' 3m & 6m performance after 20 March 2003



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

benefits from its outsized influence on global finance and geopolitics.

In practical terms, these attributes mean that CHF, JPY and USD often appreciate during risk-off episodes, providing a natural hedge for portfolios exposed to riskier assets or Emerging Markets (EMs).

Risk: The degree of currency strength can vary based on the specific nature of the shock and prevailing global conditions.

For example, the recent shock in currency markets has been driven primarily by concerns over oil supply, stemming from the ongoing Middle East conflict. Japan, as one of the world's largest importers of crude oil, is particularly exposed to these risks, as it sources around 95% of its crude oil and 11% of its liquefied natural gas (LNG) from the Middle East. Notably, approximately 70% of this oil is transported via the Strait of Hormuz, a route vulnerable to disruption during periods of regional instability. Consequently, amid the heightened volatility and uncertainty in the Middle East, the JPY is not likely to serve as the most dependable safe-haven currency, given Japan's increased susceptibility to energy import supply and transit risks.

How to manage CHF leverage?

Since CHF has appreciated this year, clients with CHF-denominated loans are seeing increased debt burdens relative to their base currency. The recent USD rebound eased pressure slightly, but volatility remains a risk. Any short-term rebounds are likely to stall near 0.78, a level that has held several times in recent months, suggesting further downside. Any direct Swiss National Bank (SNB) intervention in FX markets or a move towards negative interest rates remain risks to our view. We expect diversified carry strategies to outperform concentrated ones.

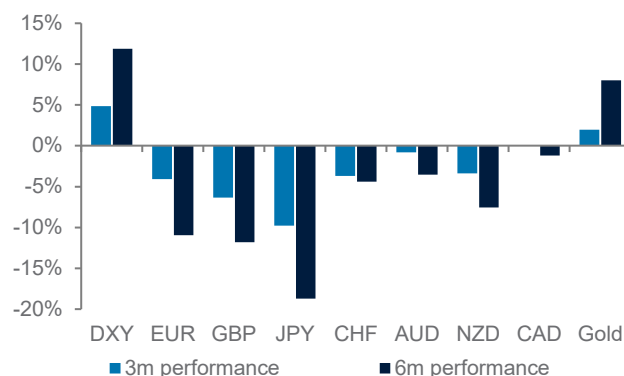
Commodity Currencies: AUD, NZD, and CAD

The **AUD** is predominantly influenced by the export of minerals such as iron ore, coal and gold, as Australia is a major global supplier of these resources. The **NZD**, in contrast, is tied to agricultural commodities, especially dairy products, meat and wool, reflecting New Zealand's status as a leading exporter in these sectors. The **CAD** is most sensitive to oil prices, as Canada is one of the world's top oil exporters, alongside its notable exports of metals and timber

These currency-commodity linkages arise because fluctuations in the prices of these key exports directly impact national income, trade balances and foreign investment flows. When commodity prices rise, these economies typically see increased export revenues and stronger currencies, while declines in prices can lead to weaker economic performance and depreciating currencies. As a result, the AUD, NZD and

At the beginning of the 2022 Russia-Ukraine conflict, major currencies fell but USD rose

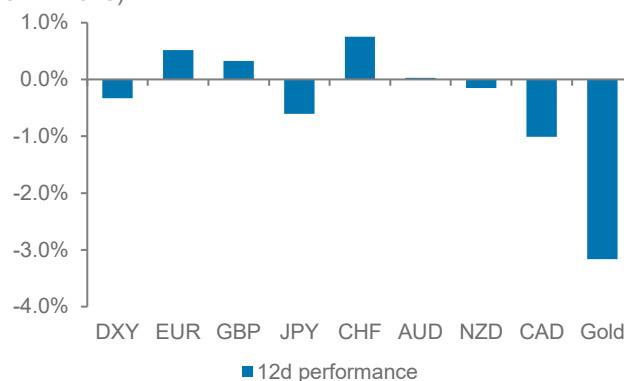
Major currencies' 3m & 6m performance after 24 February 2022



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

During the 12-day Israel-Iran conflict in 2025, major currencies varied and USD fell

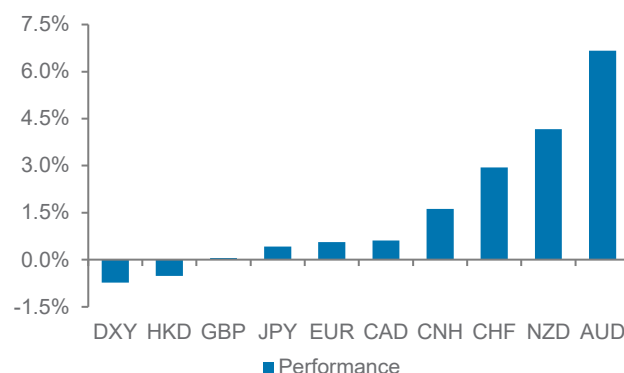
Major currencies' performance during the period (13-24 June 2025)



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Before 2026 Middle East Conflict

Major currencies' performance



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

CAD often move in tandem with the fortunes of the commodities most central to their respective economies.

Risk: The currency-commodity relationship is not perfectly linear. Factors such as monetary policy and global risk appetite also play a role.

Portfolio Implications: Enduring Features and USD Strength

Understanding these structural currency characteristics is essential for constructing resilient FX portfolios. In the current environment, marked by pronounced USD strength, several practical implications emerge:

- **Diversification Benefits:** Allocating to a mix of safe-haven and commodity currencies can enhance portfolio diversification, as their drivers often differ and may respond inversely to global shocks.
- **Risk Mitigation:** Exposure to safe-haven currencies can provide a buffer during risk-off periods, while commodity currencies may offer upside in cyclical recoveries or when commodity prices surge.
- **USD Considerations:** Sustained USD appreciation can pose challenges for global portfolios, particularly those with unhedged exposure to emerging or commodity-linked currencies. Rebalancing strategies and selective hedging can help manage these risks while capturing opportunities presented by currency misalignments.

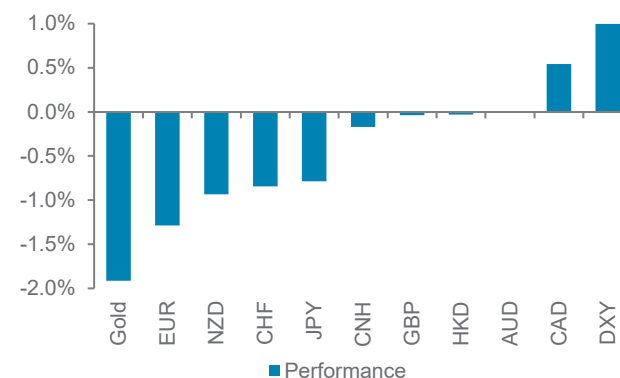
Key Takeaways

The enduring features that distinguish safe-haven and commodity currencies provide a valuable lens for interpreting FX market moves, especially amid heightened volatility. By focusing on liquidity, reserve status, capital flows and the economic underpinnings of commodity exporters, investors can better navigate currency risks and position their portfolios for resilience and opportunity across cycles. Maintaining a disciplined approach grounded in the evergreen insights we've discussed is vital, regardless of the prevailing market narrative.

— **Jonathan Liang, CFA**, CIO – Fixed Income & FX
— **Iris Yuen**, Investment Strategist

After 2026 Middle East Conflict

Major currencies' performance



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

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Market Watch

Oil surges above USD 100/bbl

Summary

Event: US crude oil prices soared above USD 100/bbl, to the highest level since the early days of the Ukraine conflict in 2022, after several Gulf oil producers started to shut production as they ran out storage. Meanwhile, the US and Iran hardened their positions, raising the risk of a prolonged conflict. Stocks and bonds slumped further, while the USD extended gains.

Our View: The impact of the Middle East conflict will depend on how long the disruption in the Strait of Hormuz lasts, with almost 20% of global oil and gas shipped through the strait. While we continue to see a 70% chance the conflict will ease in weeks, there is rising risk the impact on energy markets could be more prolonged, hurting growth and lifting inflation this year (the so-called stagflation scenario).

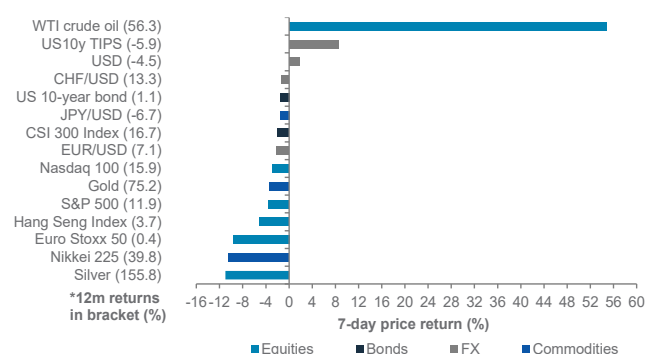
Investment strategy: Since the outlook remains fluid, a prudent strategy would involve a diversified allocation, with a slight preference for USD assets (given the US status as a net oil exporter). US energy, aerospace and defence and utilities sector equities and US inflation-protected bonds should offer partial hedges if oil prices remain elevated. Gold has historically outperformed most assets in stagflation scenarios.

Hardened positions, halting oil production

The US and Iran hardened their positions. US President Trump said over the weekend he is considering targeting Iran's nuclear facilities, adding short-term oil price spikes are "a very small price to pay". Meanwhile, Iran named Mojtaba Khamenei, the son of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei who was killed last week, as its next Supreme Leader. The hardening of stance and continued attack on energy infrastructure across

Crude oil prices surged above USD 100/bbl; US inflation-protected bonds and USD have gained, while Asian and European stocks have underperformed

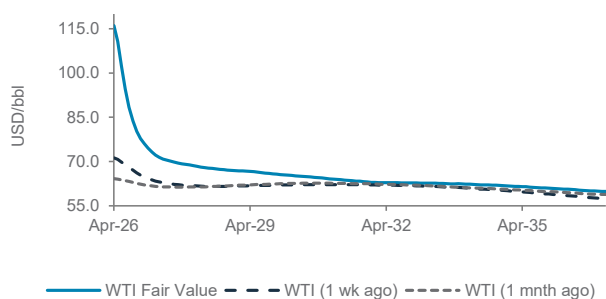
Asset performance: 27-Feb close to 9-Mar (1PM HKT)



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

We expect oil prices to fall back below USD 100/bbl in the coming weeks as the conflict de-escalates; this view is aligned with oil futures markets

WTI crude oil futures price curve



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

the region raises the risk the Hormuz strait remains out of bounds for oil and gas tankers for weeks.

Production halts start amid storage capacity shortage.

Over the weekend, Iraq, the UAE and Kuwait announced production shutdown in key oil and gas facilities as storage capacity starts to run out. Qatar has already closed the world's largest LNG facility, taking a fifth of global LNG offline. The Gulf region accounts for a third of global oil supplies.

Rising inflation, slowing growth risks. The International Monetary Fund (IMF) said a 10% rise in energy prices for a year lifts global inflation by 40bps and slows economic growth by 0.1-0.2%. WTI oil prices have almost doubled from last year's average USD 65/bbl to near-USD 120/bbl this morning. The IMF said oil importing and low-income countries would be the worst impacted from elevated prices.

Base scenario

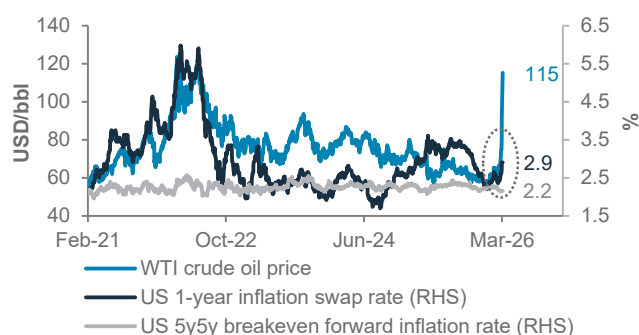
Short Iran conflict; oil prices fall back after near-term spike: Oil futures markets remain in backwardation (elevated near-term prices and lower-than-USD 100/bbl oil from June 2026), suggesting markets expect the impact of the conflict to be short-lived. This differs from the Ukraine conflict, when oil prices stayed above USD 100/bbl for almost five months.

This aligns with our view of a 70% probability that the conflict is likely to last for a few weeks, rather than months, due to: a) Iran's severely depleted military capacity; b) US plans to provide military support and insurance coverage to restart shipping through the Hormuz strait; c) Trump's limited tolerance for a prolonged conflict ahead of mid-term elections; and d) potential pressure from China on Iran to restart talks (China, and Asia, among the most impacted from prolonged conflict, given dependence on Middle East oil and gas).

Moreover, today's macro landscape is different from 2022 when the Ukraine conflict started – Europe's energy supplies are significantly more diversified (with the US a key source).

US short-term and long-term inflation expectations remain subdued despite surge in oil prices

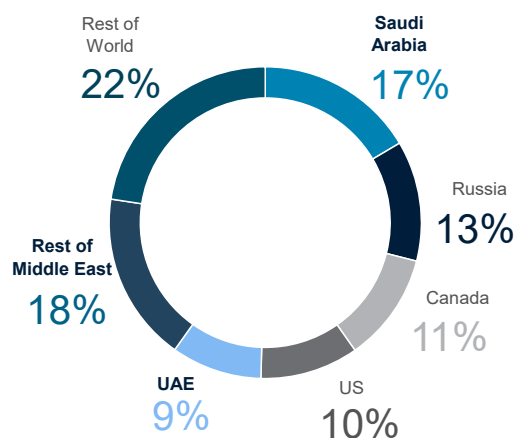
WTI crude oil price, 1-year and 5-year market inflation expectations



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

The Gulf countries are the source of more than a third of global oil exports

Share of various regions in world oil exports



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

The OECD countries and China have sufficient oil reserves to meet demand for months. G7 countries are reportedly considering releasing some of their oil reserves. Also, inflation is on a downtrend globally, unlike in 2022 when the world was facing pandemic-related supply bottlenecks and inflation was on an uptrend. These factors suggest oil prices are unlikely to stay elevated for a prolonged period and are likely to fall back towards USD 70-80bbl in a few months, if not weeks.

Risk scenario

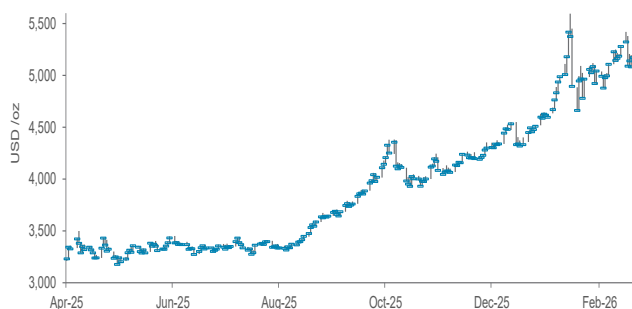
Prolonged Iran conflict: While not our base case, there is a 30% chance that Iran leverages its low-cost drones to sustain attacks on key energy targets across the Middle East, stalling shipping traffic through the Hormuz strait for months. UAE, Kuwait and Iraq have already started to cut oil output as they run out of storage as the Hormuz strait is perceived to be unsafe for tankers. This scenario would see oil staying above USD 100/bbl for months, similar to the aftermath of the start of the Ukraine conflict in 2022.

Such an outcome would raise global gasoline prices and inflation expectations, while hurting real incomes and consumption, increasing stagflation risks. This scenario would delay central bank rate cuts or, in the extreme case, force many Emerging Market central banks to hike rates. In the US though, we expect this outcome to hurt an already fragile US job market (US payrolls surprisingly contracted in February, before the conflict escalated), forcing the Fed to eventually step in and cut rates, albeit later than current estimates i.e. Fed cuts more likely pushed back to next year in this scenario.

There is also the tail risk (~5% chance) that Trump caps US oil prices, given US's status as the world's largest oil producer (accounting for a fifth of global output) and a net oil exporter. US shale output would become profitable and rise if

Gold remains a critical tactical and structural portfolio hedge amid geopolitical uncertainty and stagflation risks

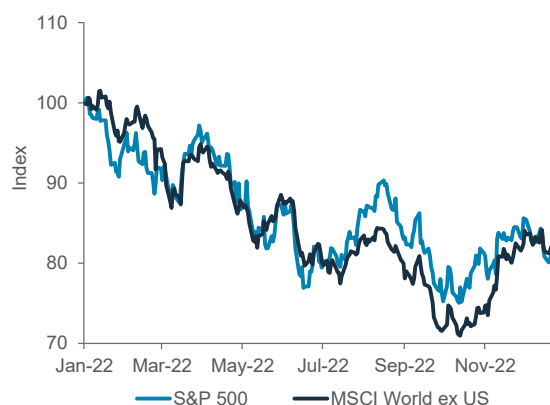
Gold price



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

During the 2022 drawdown, global and US equities global equities declined between 25-30% from peak to trough

S&P500 and MSCI World ex-US equity indices (Index: 100 = 1 Jan 2022)



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

the price cap is set above USD 65/bbl, based on breakeven price for shale producers according to a Dallas Fed survey.

Investment Strategy

Stay diversified, avoid concentration, build hedges: USD assets broadly, US energy equities and inflation-protected bonds are among the key hedges against an oil-led inflation spike. US energy equities offer moderately high correlation with oil prices. Any cap in US oil prices would benefit non-energy stocks and hurt energy and materials sectors, though.

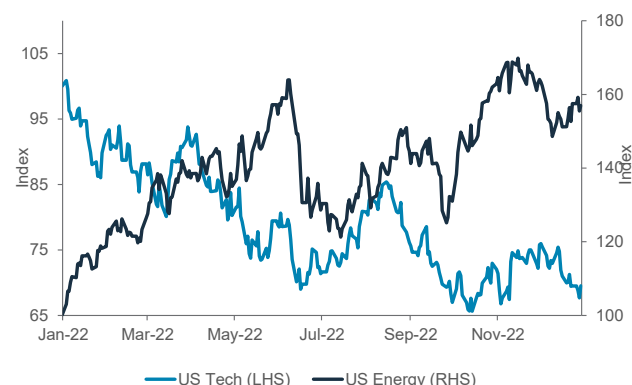
Gold, oil-based currencies to benefit as well. Although gold pulled back last week from near-record highs amid USD strength, history shows it is one of the best hedges against stagflation risks. We have a 6% allocation to gold in our balanced allocation. Oil and commodity-based currencies such CAD, NOK and AUD are likely to benefit, while Asian oil importer currencies are likely to weaken, in the short term.

Next focus: Apart from Middle East developments and the shape of the oil price curve, February's US consumer inflation report, due on Wednesday will be the next focus. The consensus estimates US inflation remained steady heading into the conflict (consensus for core inflation: 0.2% m/m, 2.5% y/y). Higher-than-expected inflation and inflation expectations would likely further push back chances of another Fed rate cut and increase near-term stagflation concerns.

— **Rajat Bhattacharya**, Senior Investment Strategist

US energy sector equities benefitted from higher oil prices in 2022, while the tech sector fell

US tech and energy sector equity performance in 2022



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

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Market Watch

China's 2026 NPC takeaways

Summary

Event: The National People's Congress (NPC) Government Work Report announced a 2026 economic growth target of 4.5-5.0%, moderating from 2025's 5.0%. Fiscal deficits and special bond issuances were broadly in line with expectations.

Our View: Moderately loose monetary policy and proactive fiscal policy are aimed at (i) boosting domestic consumption and investment, (ii) fostering innovation, and (iii) signaling commitment to curbing deflation and managing risks.

Investment strategy: Policy support reinforces our overweight view on China within Asia ex Japan equities. Policy direction aligns with our barbell strategy that favours both high dividend non-financial state-owned-enterprise H shares and the Hang Seng technology sector.

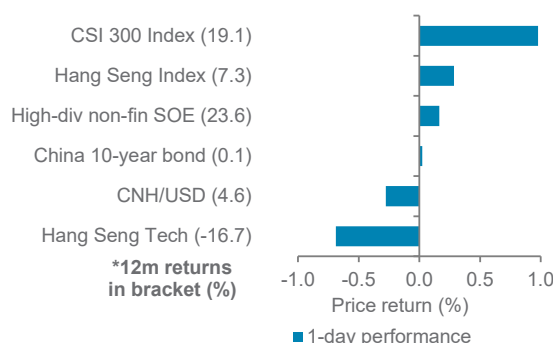
We expect CNH to be rangebound in the near term given the growth target and uncertainty in the Middle East, but expect USD/CNH to trend towards 6.75 in 12 months.

Key NPC target highlights

Premier Li Qiang delivered the Government Work Report as the NPC commenced on 5 March. The GDP growth forecast this year has been set at 4.5-5%, the CPI target set at 2% and the official fiscal deficit at 4% of GDP. The growth target, while lower than last year's 5%, is in line with our expectation and should be viewed as pragmatic amidst the volatile external environment and domestic challenges, as China embarks the 15th 5-Year Period (5YP) with a focus on growth quality and risk control. This quality focus is illustrated by the commitment to cutting carbon dioxide emissions per GDP unit by 3.8% this year and 17% over the next 5 years.

China asset class performance since NPC started

1-day and 12-month asset class returns, as of 5 March



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Key 2026 Government Work Report targets

	2026 Target	2025 Achieved	2025 Target
Real GDP growth	4.5%-5%	5%	5%
CPI	2%	0.1%	2%
Official budget deficit (% GDP)	~4%	4%	4%
Ultra-long central govt bond issuance (CNY tn)	1.3	1.3	1.3
Special bond issuance for large banks (CNY tn)	0.3	0.5	0.5
Urban unemployment rate	5.5%	5.2%	5.5%
Urban job creation	>12m	12.67m	12m

Source: NPC, Standard Chartered

Monetary and fiscal policy support

Moderately loose monetary policy: Policymakers aim to overcome deflationary pressures through continued pursuit of moderately loose monetary policy. This includes a flexible reduction in the reserve requirement ratio and policy rates to lower funding costs while maintaining a stable CNY.

Fiscal stimulus taking the driver's seat: The official budget deficit is targeted at 4% of GDP, pushing public budget expenditure to a new high of CNY 30tn. Proposed ultra-long special government bond issuance is CNY 1.3tn, aimed at supporting strategic security and infrastructure projects as well as consumption and equipment upgrades. Special bond issuance aimed at shoring up bank capital, however, was lowered to CNY 0.3tn (from CNY 0.5tn in 2025).

Foster technology innovation and stimulate investment: Authorities are focused on accelerating the development of an AI open-source community, semiconductors, biotech and a 'low-altitude economy'. To lift the contribution of the digital economy from 10.5% now to 12.5% of GDP over the 15th FYP, several frontier industries were identified as key areas of development, namely, quantum computing, embodied intelligence, brain-computer interface, future energy, aerospace, and 6G. CNY 200bn has been earmarked for large-scale equipment upgrade.

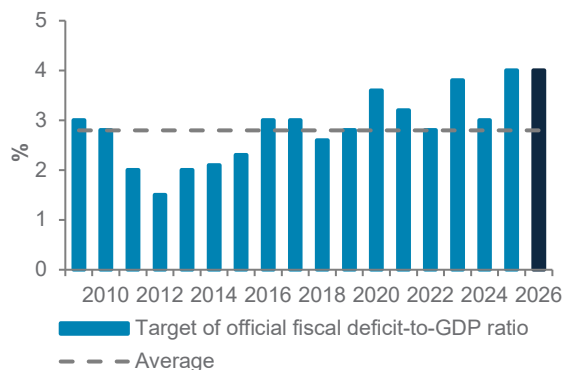
Broaden consumption support to services and rebalance trade: Consumer goods trade-in subsidies were scaled back to CNY 250bn from CNY 300bn in 2025, but a CNY 100bn fund has been set up for loan interest subsidies and financing guarantees for service providers to grow consumption beyond 40% of GDP. Also, measures such as better social welfare coverage, improved housing conditions for the newly-wed or first child, and reduced negative list for cross-border trade are aimed at enhancing sentiment and narrowing trade imbalances.

Tackle irrational competition and property risks: Efforts are expected to be intensified at a sector level to monitor market pricing and implement capacity control, in order to stabilize pricing and enhance profit margins, helping to counter deflationary pressures. As for the property sector, the focus seems to have shifted from stemming price declines to supply-led stability, including ensuring timely delivery, providing ample quality affordable housing, as well as managing inventory at the local level.

— **Raymond Cheng, CFA, CPA**
Chief Investment Officer, North Asia

China keeps its official fiscal deficit at a historic high level of 4% of GDP to bolster economic growth

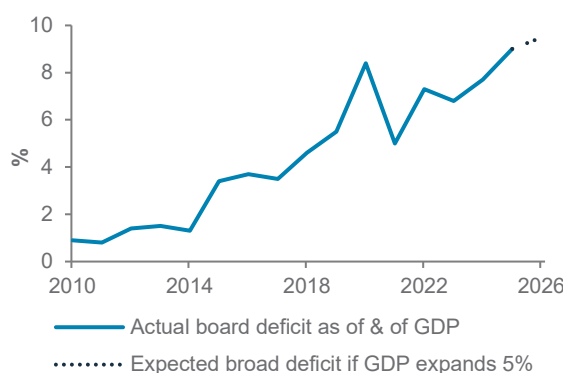
China's annual official fiscal deficit target (% of GDP)



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

China's broad deficit to GDP ratio is expected to continue rising towards 10%

Annual broad deficit (% of GDP)



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Curbing irrational competition a component of strategy to contain deflationary pressures

CPI index %y/y



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

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Market Watch presentation

Iran – watching oil prices

A guide for volatile markets

March 2026

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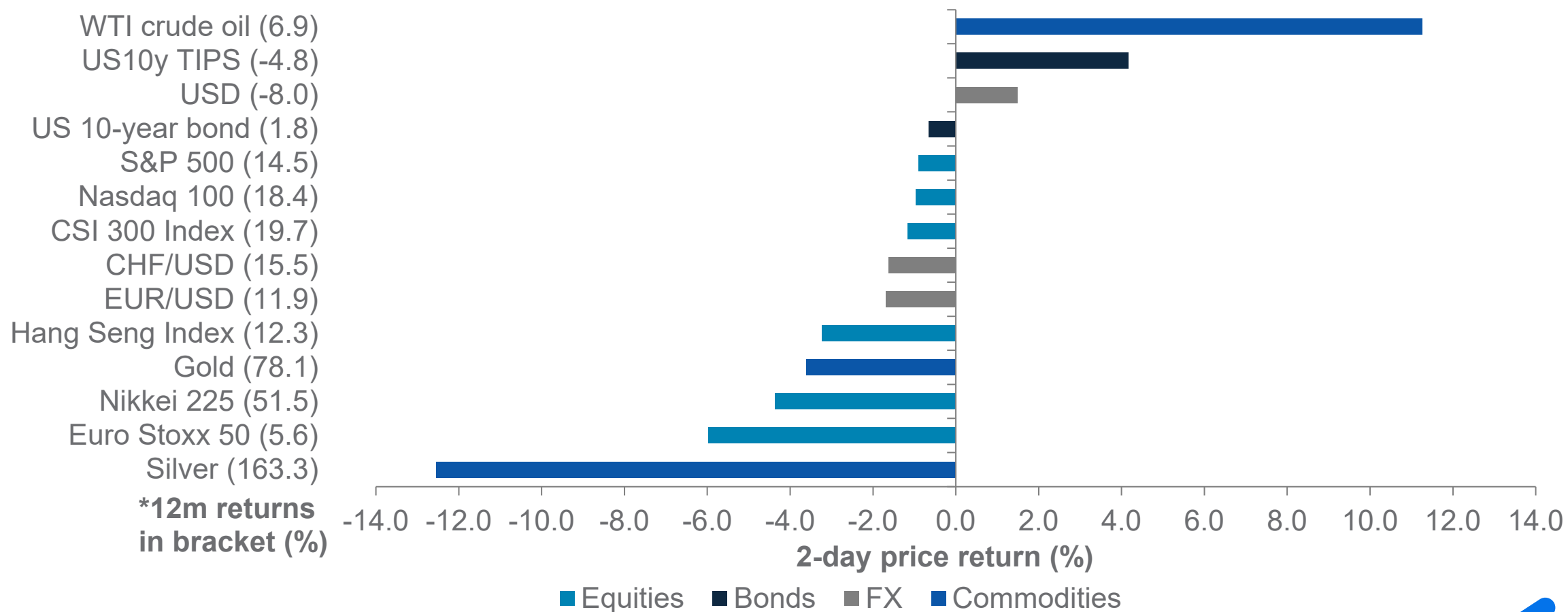


What is happening in markets today?



Stocks slump, while oil, inflation-linked bonds and USD rise amid the Iran crisis

Asset class returns, 2-days and over 12 months

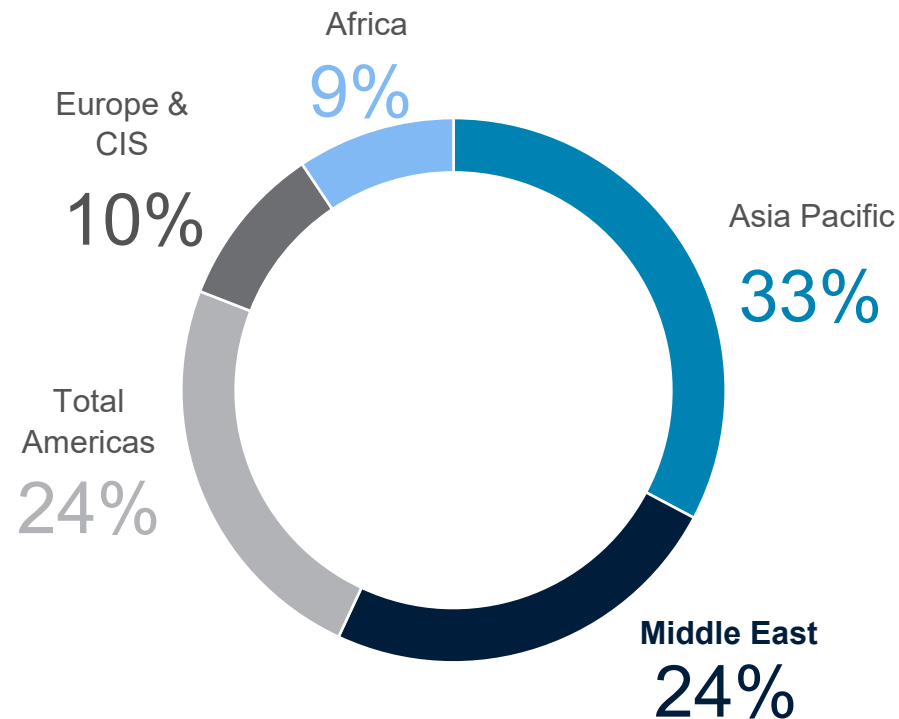
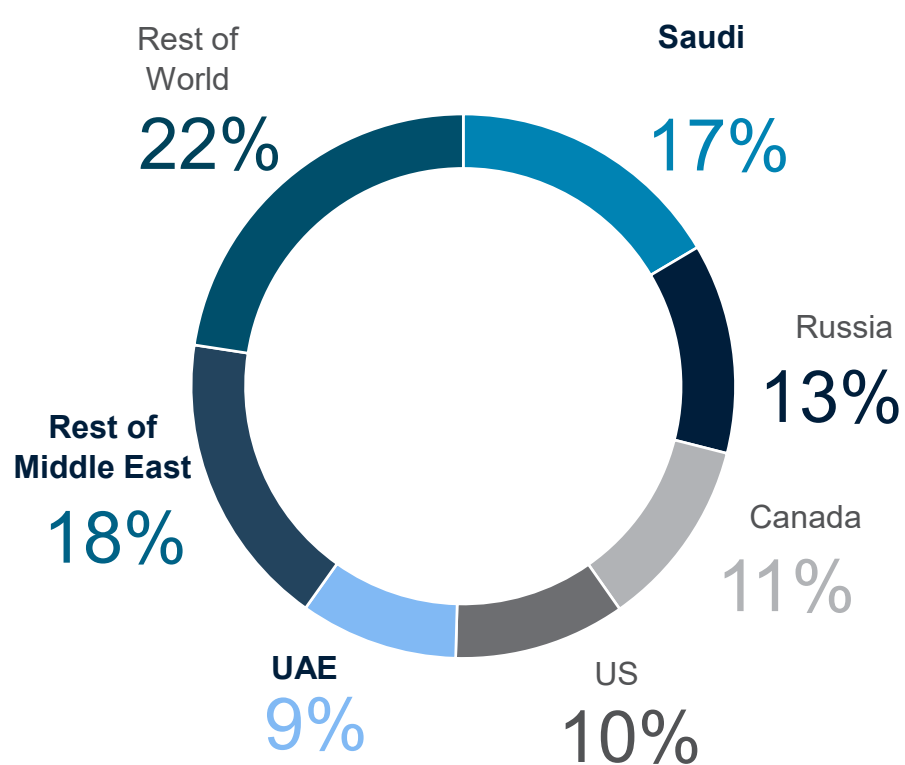


Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered. As of 3-Mar-2026 close.



Iran conflict impacts a region providing significant global oil & gas supplies

Share of various regions in global crude oil (LHS) and liquefied natural gas (RHS) exports

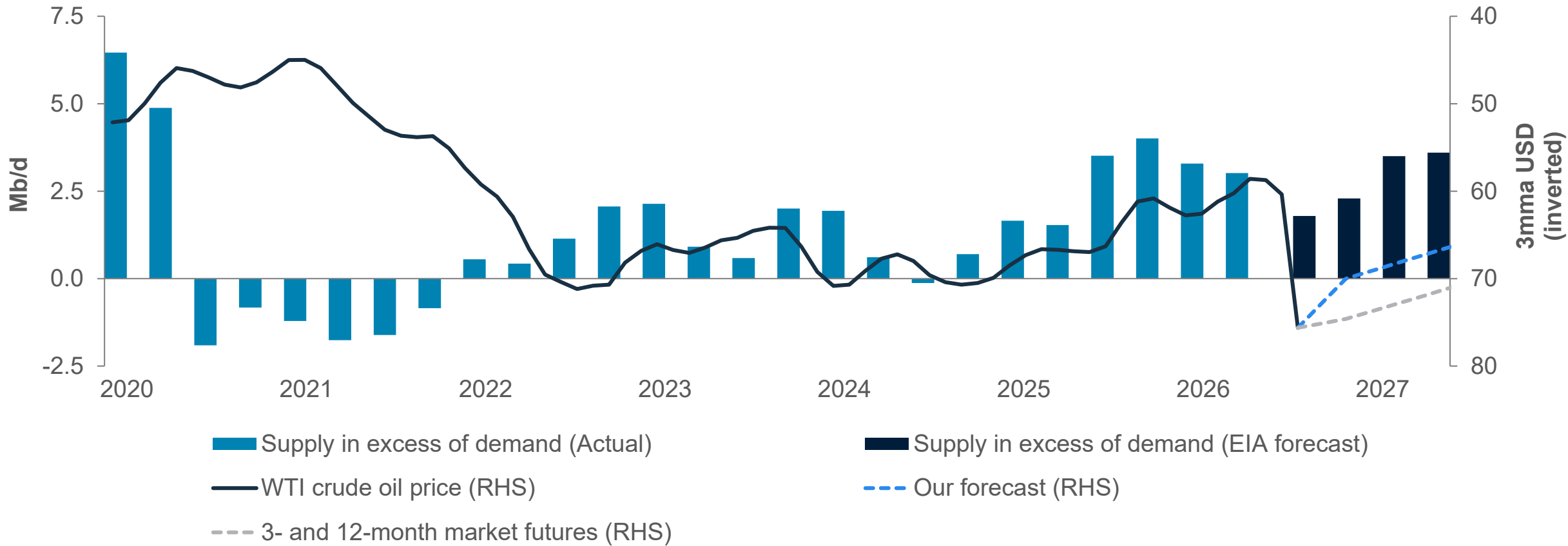


Source: Energy Institute Statistical Review, Standard Chartered



Oil: The oil market is in surplus, but most excess supplies are in the Middle East (Saudi Arabia and UAE); open Hormuz Strait shipping lane key for markets

Total world crude oil supply vs. demand

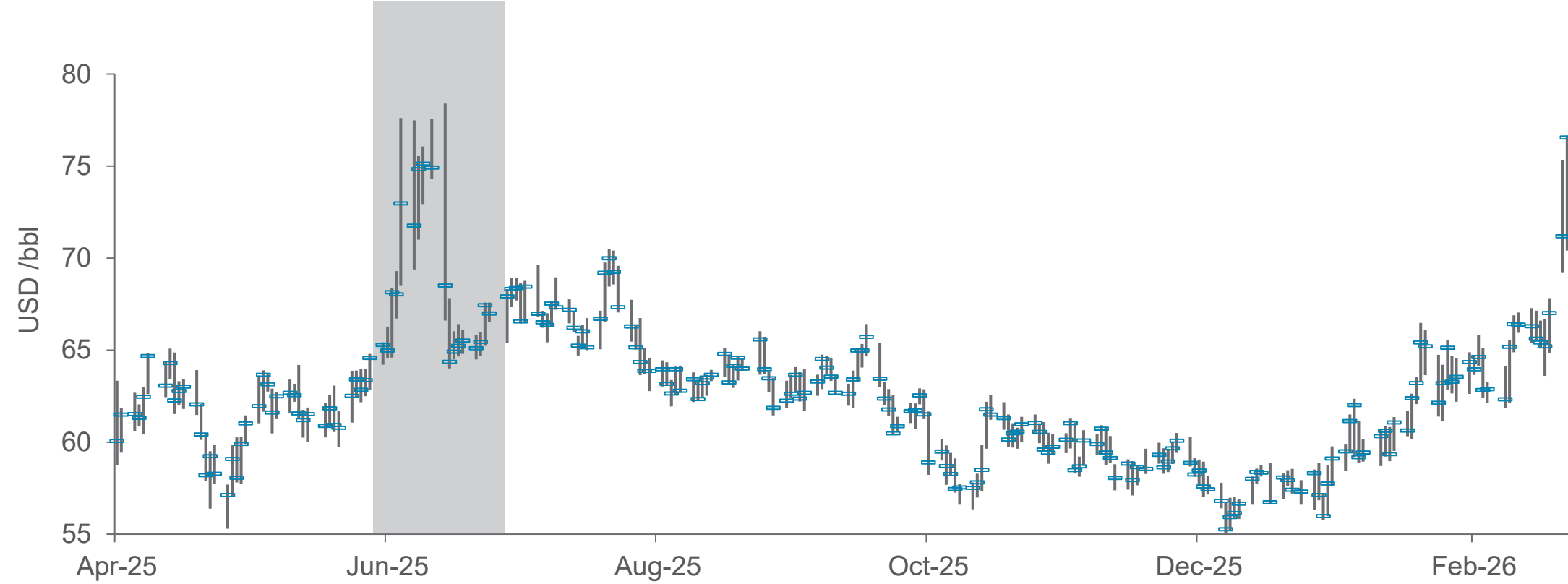


Source: EIA, Bloomberg, Standard Chartered



Our base scenario is a short-lived conflict, similar to mid-2025 12-day war; oil prices could rise briefly towards USD 80/bbl, before retracing to c. USD 60/bbl

WTI crude oil prices (high, low and daily close prices)



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered



What are our views?



Three scenarios: A short conflict lasting a few weeks remains our core scenario

- Focus to return to strong economic and corporate earning fundamentals, Fed rate cuts and global benefits of a weak USD
- CIO base case – S&P 500 12-month target at 7,800

Our base case assumptions

- US avoids recession in 2026, grows <1.8%
- US 2026 CPI to be above 2% target
- Fed cuts by 75bps to 3% by Dec-26
- USD weakens further over 12 months
- 10-year US Treasury yield falls to 3.75% by Dec-26
- Gold prices to rise, with a target of USD 5,350/oz by Dec-26

Scenarios (by Dec-26)	Spot*	 Few days war 10%	 Few weeks war 60%	 Prolonged conflict 30%
Fed funds rate (upper bound)	3.75%	3.0%	3.00%	3.75-4.25%
S&P 500	6,882	7,800	7,800	4,800
UST 10Y	4.09%	3.50%-4.0%	3.75%	0.1%-2.1%
DXY	98.9	96	96	Global recession scenario: 105 US recession scenario: 90
US high yield spread	289bps	280-300bps	290bps	450-800bps
Gold	USD 5,320/oz	USD 5,350/oz	USD 5,350/oz	USD 5,500/oz
Outlook		Significant equities rally, bonds mixed Risk assets to rally, rebounding the brief selloff, if the war ends in a few days. Emerging Market equities and bonds to lead the rebound as oil prices fall back to USD 60bbl amid ample supplies. USD to resume weakness	Equities higher, bonds slightly higher AI monetization gathering momentum, resilient labour market and consumption, helped by central bank rate cuts, Economy avoids recession, but grows below trend, enabling rates to stay low	Bonds down, equities down Stagflation risk from higher oil prices leads to rising unemployment, higher inflation and valuation de-rating in equities, Fed holds or hikes rates due to rising inflation expectations.
Assets to Add		Equities, EM bonds	Equities, Gold	Gold, inflation-protected US government bonds, alternatives, USD (in global recession scenario)
Assets to Avoid		Credit, USD	Credit, USD	Equities, Credit, importer currencies

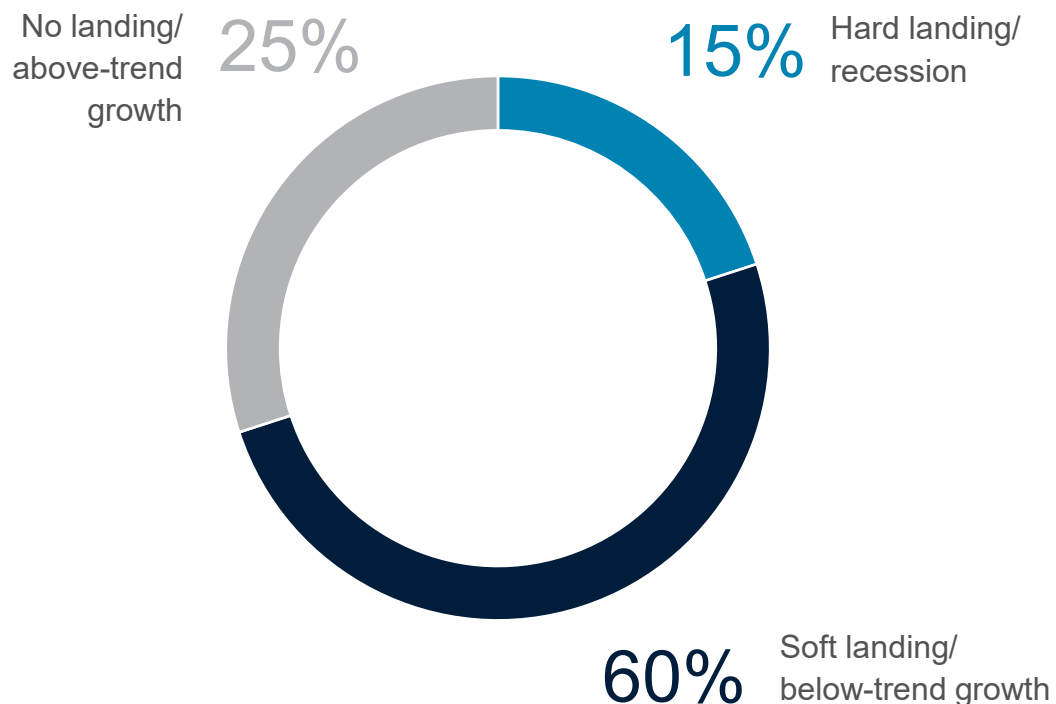
Source: Standard Chartered; Bloomberg, as of 3 March 2026



Macro: 'Soft-landing' central scenario. Rising inflation expectations a risk

Soft-landing still our base case, but rising odds of a 'hard-landing' and rising inflation expectations

Long-term expectations remain subdued but short-term inflation expectations have risen this week

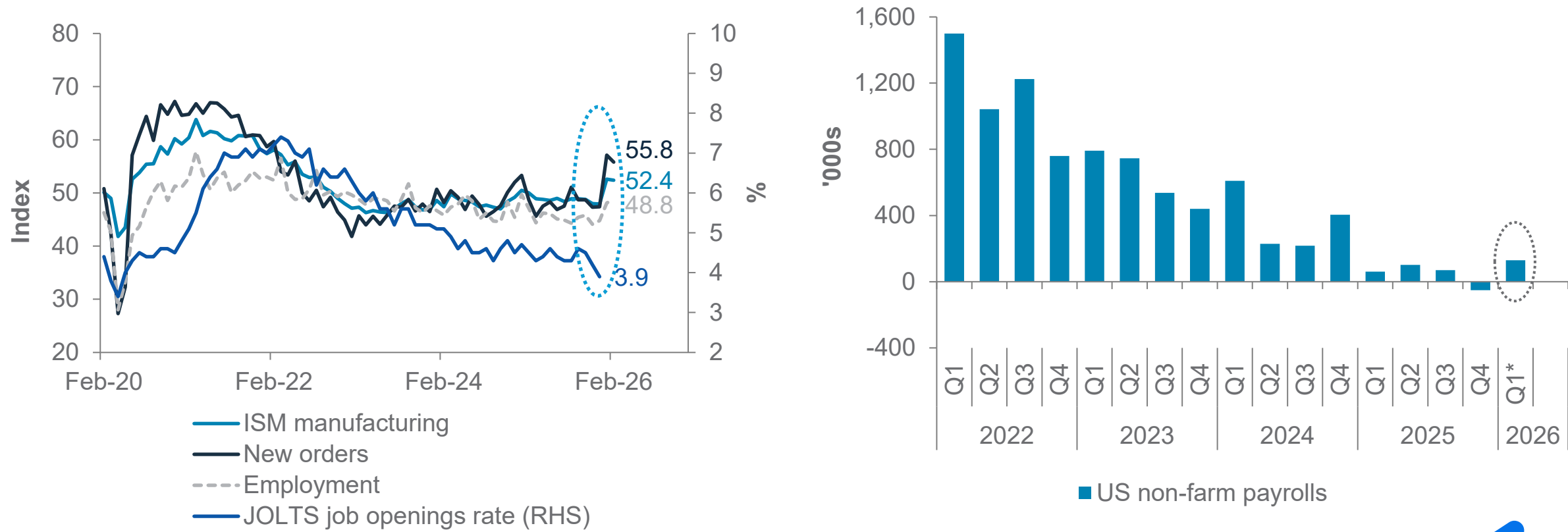


Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered



Macro: While US activity indicators are recovering, a still-tepid job market points to further Fed to cut rates to 3% by December 2026

As job market stays soft and tariff impact on inflation remains limited, we see three 25bps Fed rate cut by end-2026



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered. *Q1'26 as of January 2026



Trump's Impossible Trinity: Keeps Trump from prolonging tensions

Trump's Impossible Trinity



Trump's Wish 1

Fight the
Iran War



Trump's Wish 2

Support a slowing
US economy



Trump's Wish 3

Not stoking inflation/
Not derailing the Fed's rate cut cycle

What has been the reality?

- Initially pushing for negotiated solution
- Supreme Court ruling against tariffs a domestic political setback, likely forcing hawkish foreign policy turn
- **Achilles' heel:** soaring oil/gas prices

Source: Standard Chartered

- **"Trump Put"** – backing off from escalating tensions when markets react negatively
- Weakening job market
- Tax cuts, AI investments to support the economy

- Inflation data on the downtrend
- Trump has this **"window of opportunity"** to push through his own geopolitical agenda, such as Iran.
- Growth outlook holding up, but long conflict to trigger inflation spike



2026 Outlook: Blowing bubbles?



Opportunistic ideas

Equity

US: Technology, pharma, utilities, aerospace and defence^

Asia: China non-financial high-divi SOEs (H-Shares), Hang Seng technology, India large & mid-cap

Europe: Banks

Fixed income

US: Treasury Inflation-Protected Securities (TIPS), short-duration HY, AAA Collateralised Loan Obligations (CLOs)

Europe: CoCo bonds*

Asia: Asia IG

Risks



Negative shock to AI theme

Inflation surprise that limits room for Fed to cut rates

Credit event that leads to systemic default risk concerns

Hawkish BoJ hurting global liquidity

*Contingent Convertibles (CoCos) are complex financial instruments. Refer to Important Information on slide 74 for further details

^ New idea



Equities: Lessons from the 2003 Iraq war suggests initial reaction a knee-jerk

After the initial correction, markets mostly recovered within 30 days. Energy, materials and defensives relatively resilient

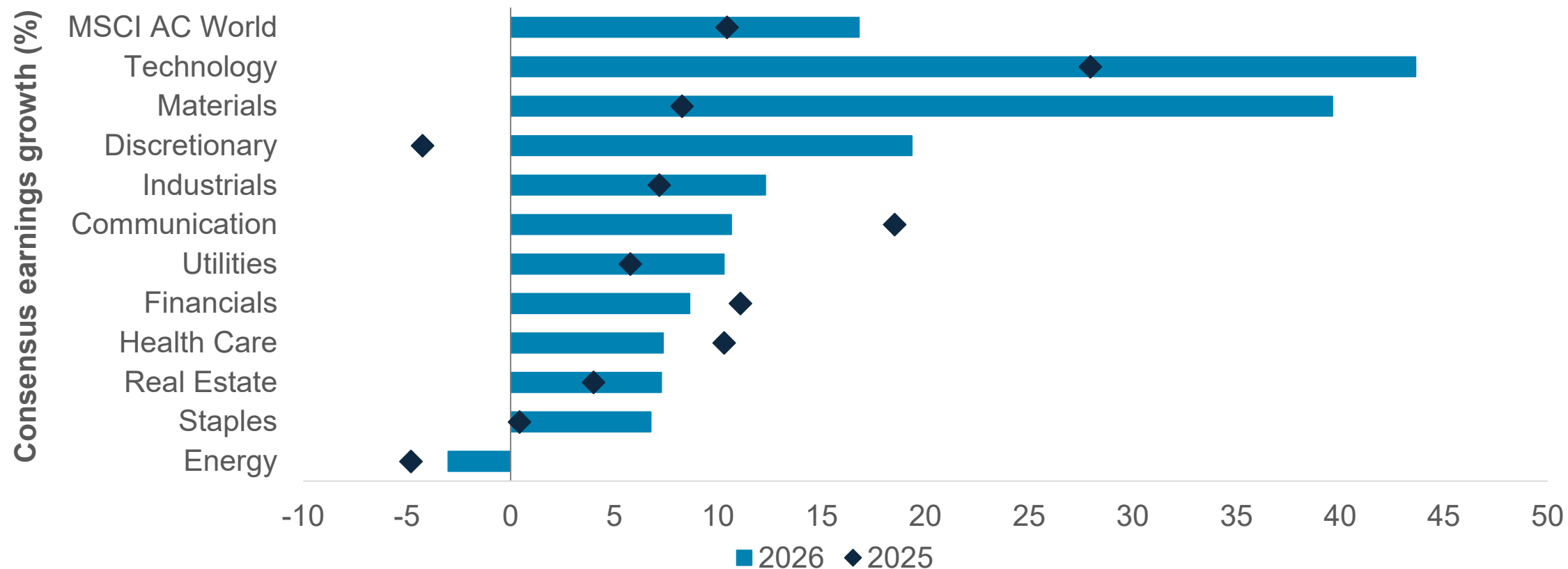
	10-day returns	30-day returns
World	-4.6%	1.1%
Energy	-1.7%	0.7%
Materials	-3.9%	1.0%
Technology	-7.9%	-0.9%
Financials	-5.4%	3.9%
Telecoms	-4.3%	0.9%
Utilities	-1.1%	4.3%
Discretionary	-5.4%	1.3%
Staples	-3.1%	0.5%
Health Care	-3.0%	-1.5%
Industrials	-5.3%	0.4%

Source: FactSet, Bloomberg, Standard Chartered



Equities: Market focus to eventually shift to fundamentals

Consensus earnings growth for MSCI AC World sectors



Source: FactSet, Bloomberg, Standard Chartered



Equities: Near-term attention on commodity-based sectors

Current MSCI weights of Energy and Materials sectors across markets

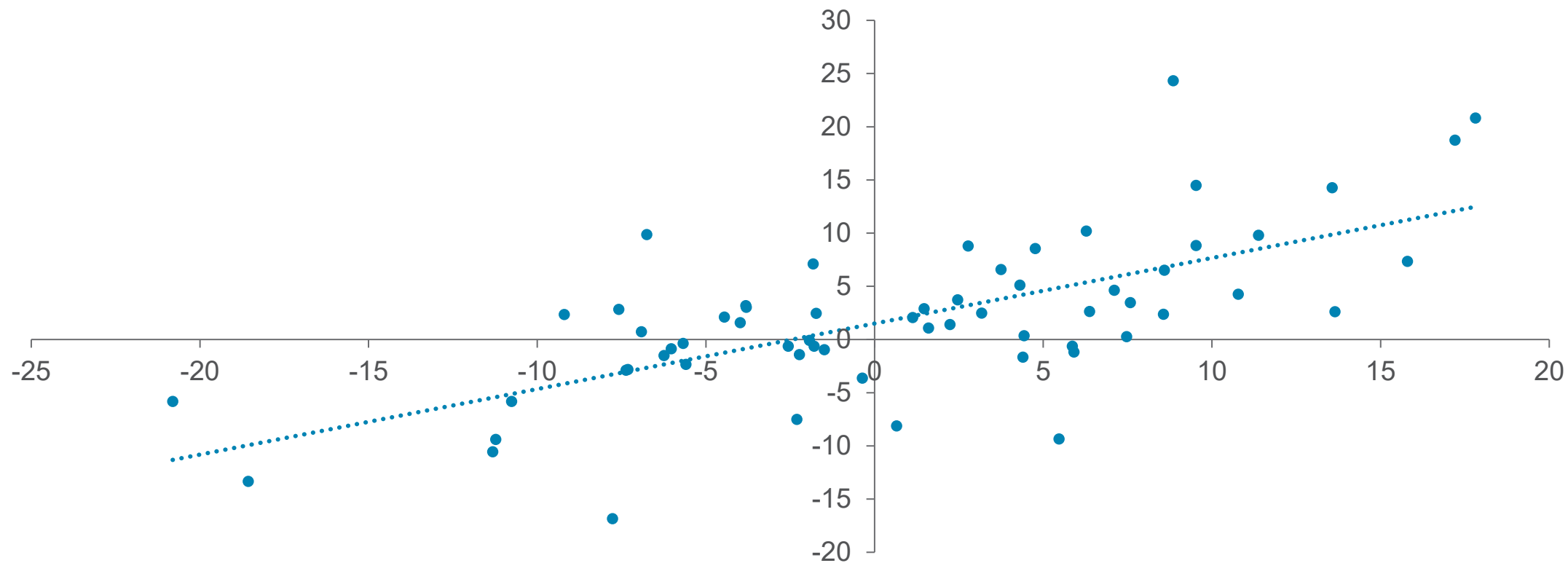
	Energy	Materials
World	3.9%	4.2%
US	3.5%	2.2%
Euro zone	3.5%	3.9%
UK	10.2%	8.6%
Asia ex Japan	2.6%	4.1%
China	2.8%	5.7%
India	8.8%	8.6%
Japan	1.0%	3.5%
Australia	3.6%	22.8%
Canada	16.9%	16.8%

Source: FactSet, Bloomberg, Standard Chartered



US energy sector equities tend to benefit from higher oil prices

Monthly percentage change in WTI crude oil price (x-axis) and US energy sector equities (y-axis)

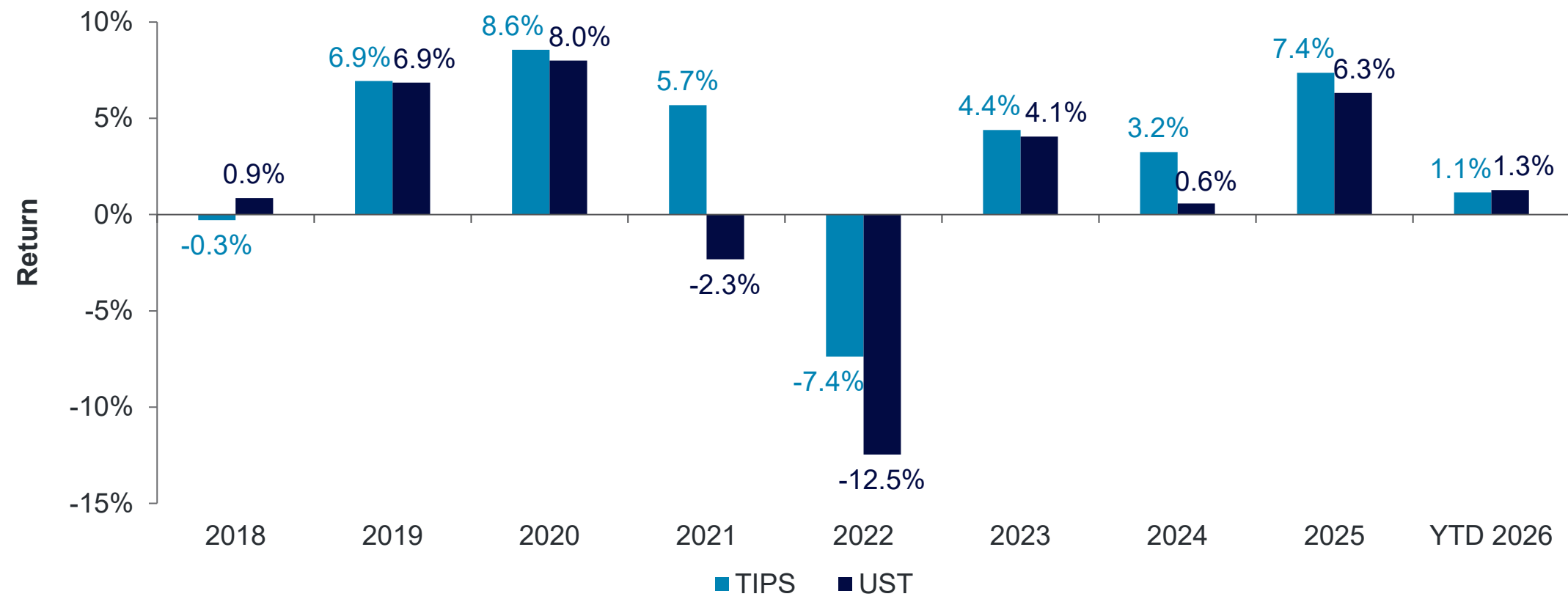


Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered



Bonds: US Treasuries benefit from risk-off scenario; US inflation-protected bonds act as a hedge during times of higher inflation

US Treasury inflation-protected securities (TIPS) and US government bonds

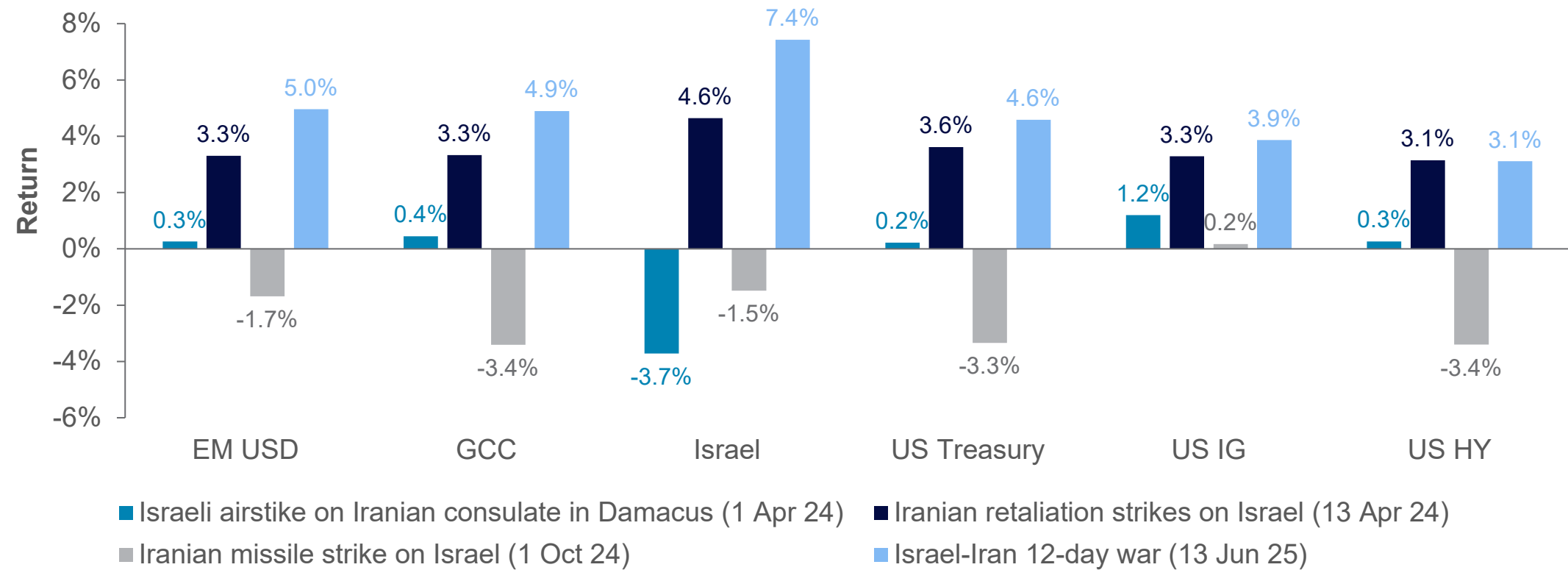


Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered



Bonds have mostly delivered positive return after prior Middle East conflicts

3-month return following escalations in recent prior Israel-Iran conflicts

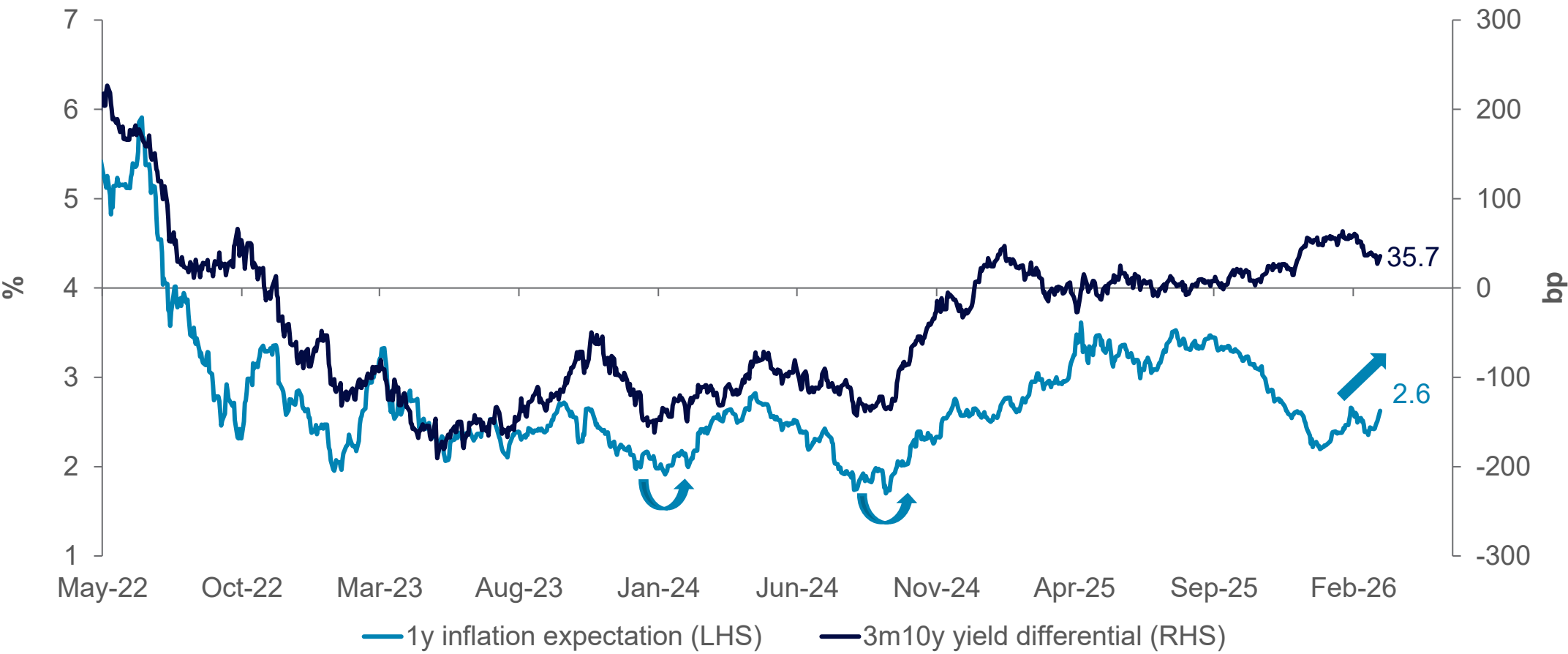


Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered



Bonds: US yield curve could steepen again as inflation expectation rises

1-year USD inflation swap rate and 10-year minus 3-month yield differentials

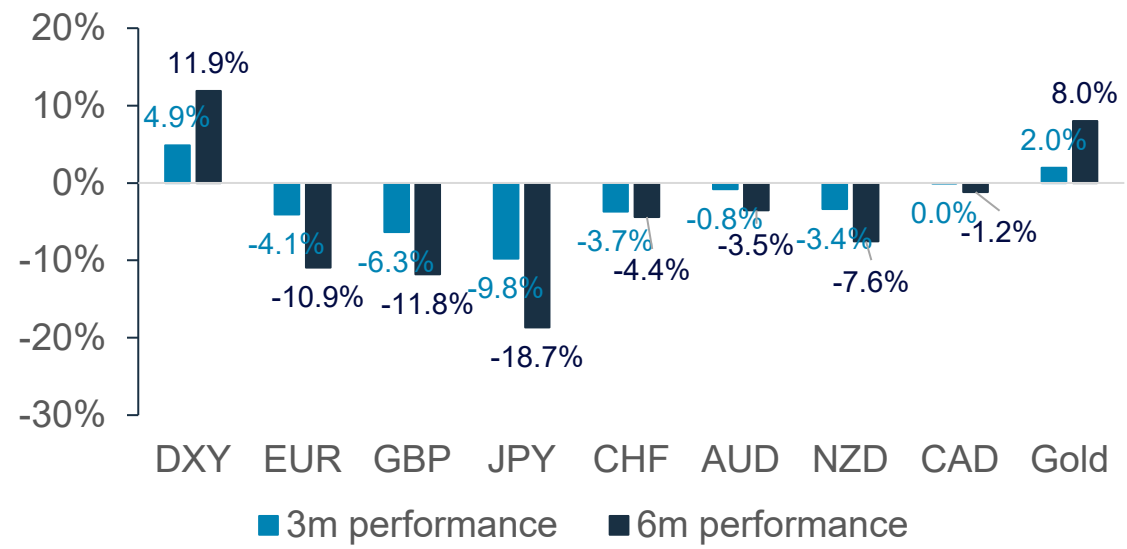


Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

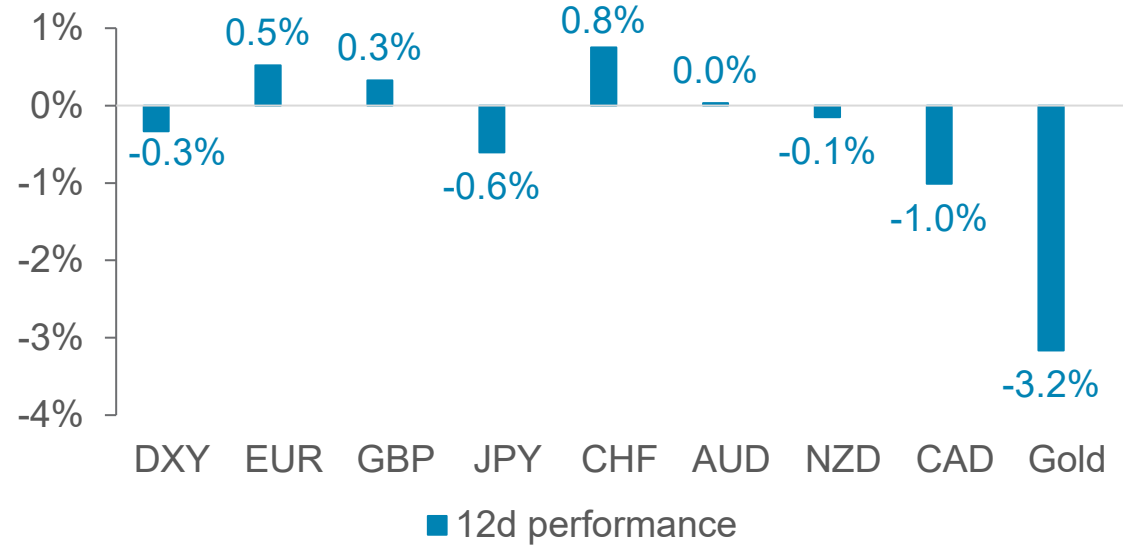


FX: USD and gold outperformed during the first six months of the Ukraine war; European currencies outperformed during last year's 12-day conflict

G7 currency performance during the first six month of the Ukraine war (Feb to Aug 2022)



G7 currency performance during 12-day US-Iran war 2025 (13 to 24 Jun 2025)

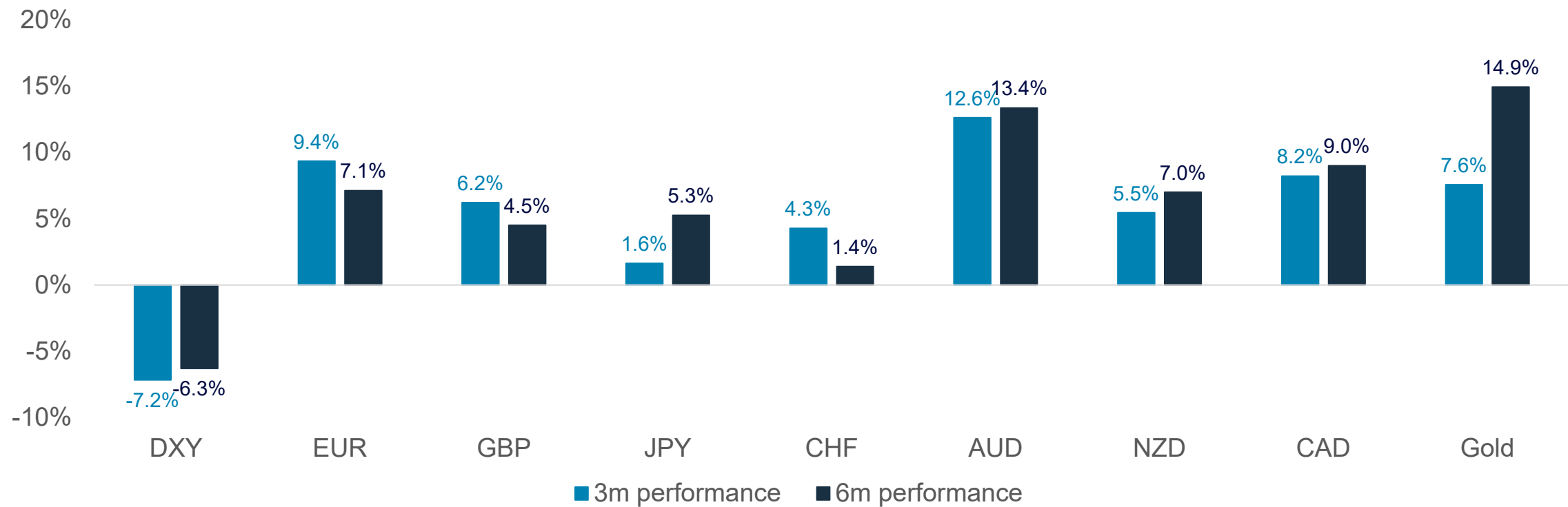


Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered



FX: USD underperformed during the Iraq invasion 2003; other currencies and gold outperformed

G7 currency performance during the first six month of the Iraq Invasion (20 March 2003)

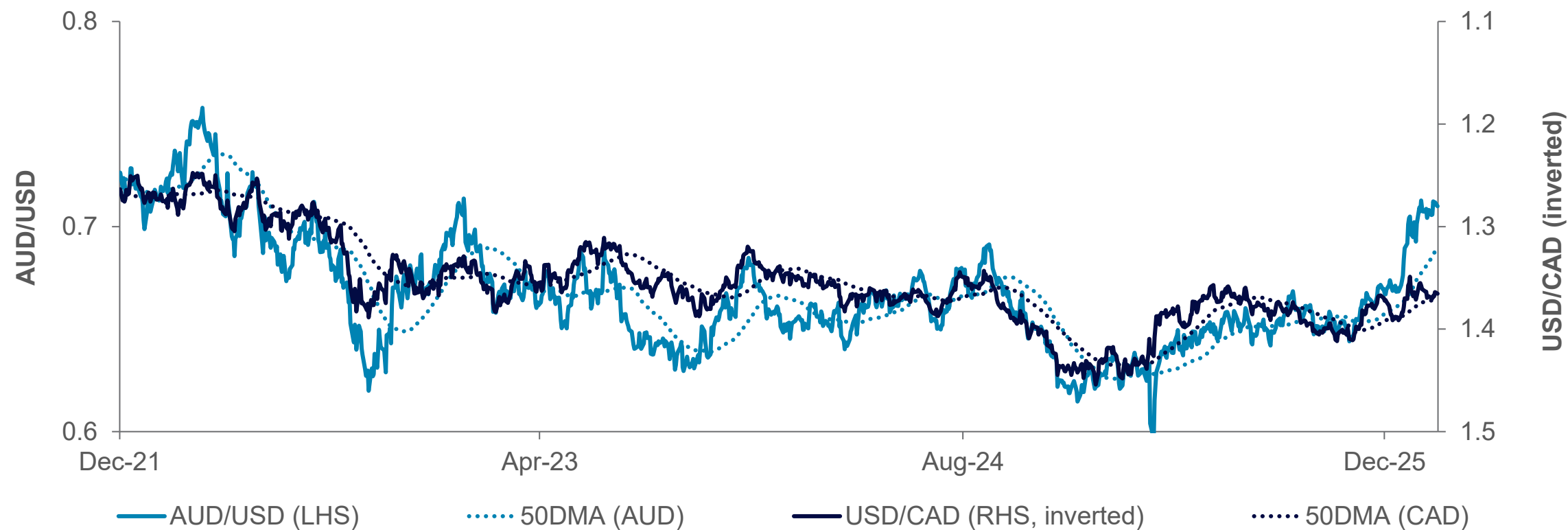


Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered



FX: Commodities currencies well supported by higher commodity prices

AUD/USD and USD/CAD (inverted)

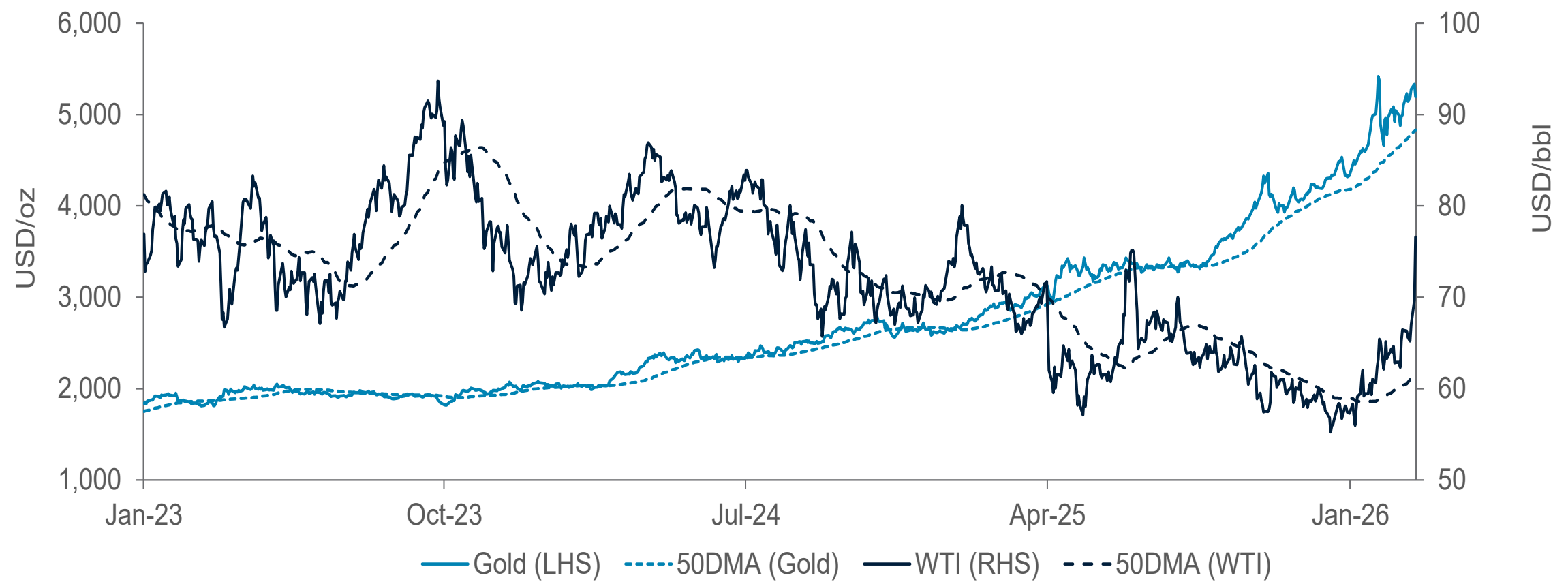


Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered



Gold has tactical and structural tailwind from heightened geopolitical risk, irrespective of the oil price

Gold and WTI crude oil prices



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered



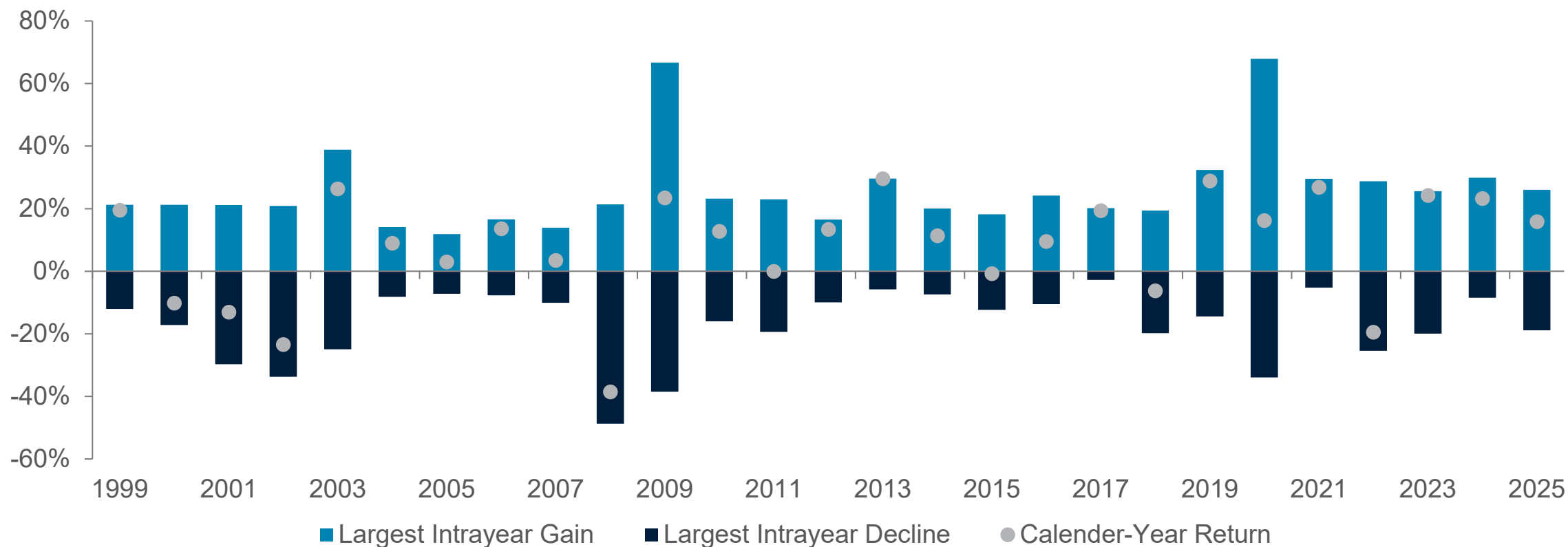
How to manage volatility?



Intra-year volatility common even during up-years

Volatility the price to pay for long-term returns

Calendar year returns, intra-year max gain and loss for S&P 500



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered



Beware: Your personality may influence your decision making

Potential biases by investor type:

- **Comfortable:** May be overconfident. Biased to inaction even as market regime has changed
- **Conservative:** Aversion to risk, which may limit losses in the downturn, but may also fail to capitalize on market upswings due to inaction or delayed decision-making
- **Enthusiastic:** Likely to be drawn to recent trends or where the action is. Likely to speculate and take undue risks



Comfortable Investor

- Scores high on **Composure, Confidence, Financial comfort, and Internal locus of control**
- Tends to be a more experienced investor
- Likely to stay relatively calm and make reasonable decisions in turbulent times
- Scores low on **Speculation and Impulsivity**



Conservative Investor

- Scores relatively high on **Financial comfort and Internal locus of control**
- Does not take too many chances and would like to have clear investing and decision-making principles
- Less likely to invest in volatile portfolios or look for guidance during times of extreme turmoil
- Less likely to make speculative moves but would benefit from establishing a contingency plan



Enthusiastic Investor

- Scores high on **Speculation, and Impulsivity**
- Tends to be less experienced and would benefit from a pre-agreed strategy
- More likely to speculate in times of market turmoil
- Would benefit from setting aside a portion of their wealth to satisfy trading impulses without jeopardising their entire wealth

Source: Standard Chartered



Be aware: Behavioural biases to be particularly aware of in down markets

Bias	What is it?	How to address it
Recency bias	Extrapolating the recent past into the future	Step back and be a student of history to understand how things might evolve
Negativity bias	Overweighting negative information or views	Step back and think about long term progress. Understand negativity gets more views/likes
Confirmation bias	Looking for people who agree with you	Actively seek people who disagree with you and can have a constructive discussion
Hindsight bias	Assuming things that have happened were so predictable	Take notes as to why you have made certain investments. Review after unexpected gains or losses
Loss aversion	The heightened fear of losing money	Look at the upside potential and the potential magnitude/longevity of losses across your whole portfolio, not individual holdings
Overconfidence	Believing you know what is going to happen	Take a probabilistic view of the world
Pessimism	Assuming markets will crash immediately after you buy or vice versa	Don't make it an all-or-nothing decision. Make small changes to start with
Sunk Cost Fallacy	Why we hold an investment even if we know we should sell it	Ask yourself "If I did not own it, would I buy it today?"
Analysis Paralysis	Over-analysing the situation	Don't make it an all-or-nothing decision. Make small changes to start with

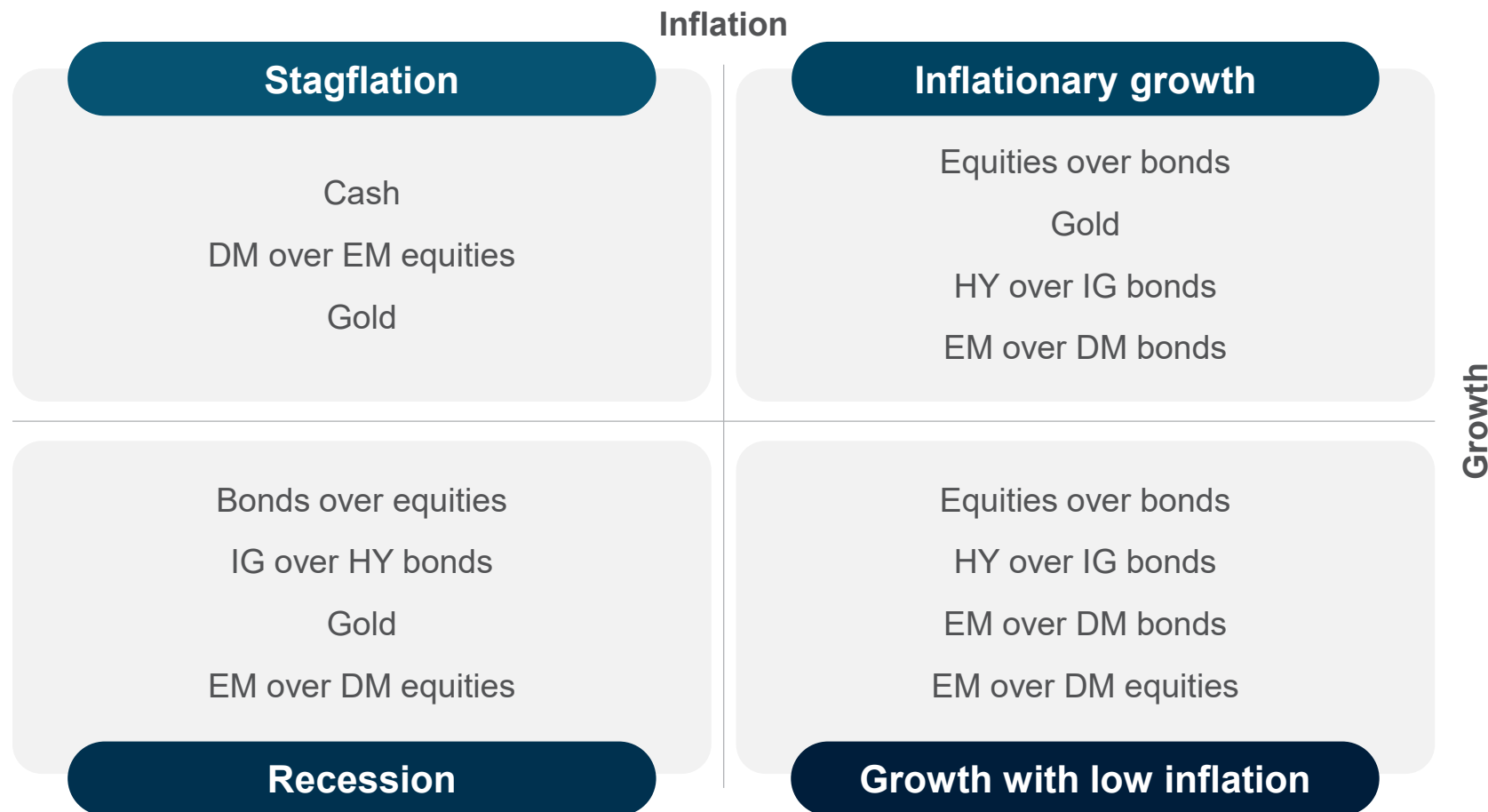
Source: Standard Chartered



When making investment decisions, think in terms of scenarios

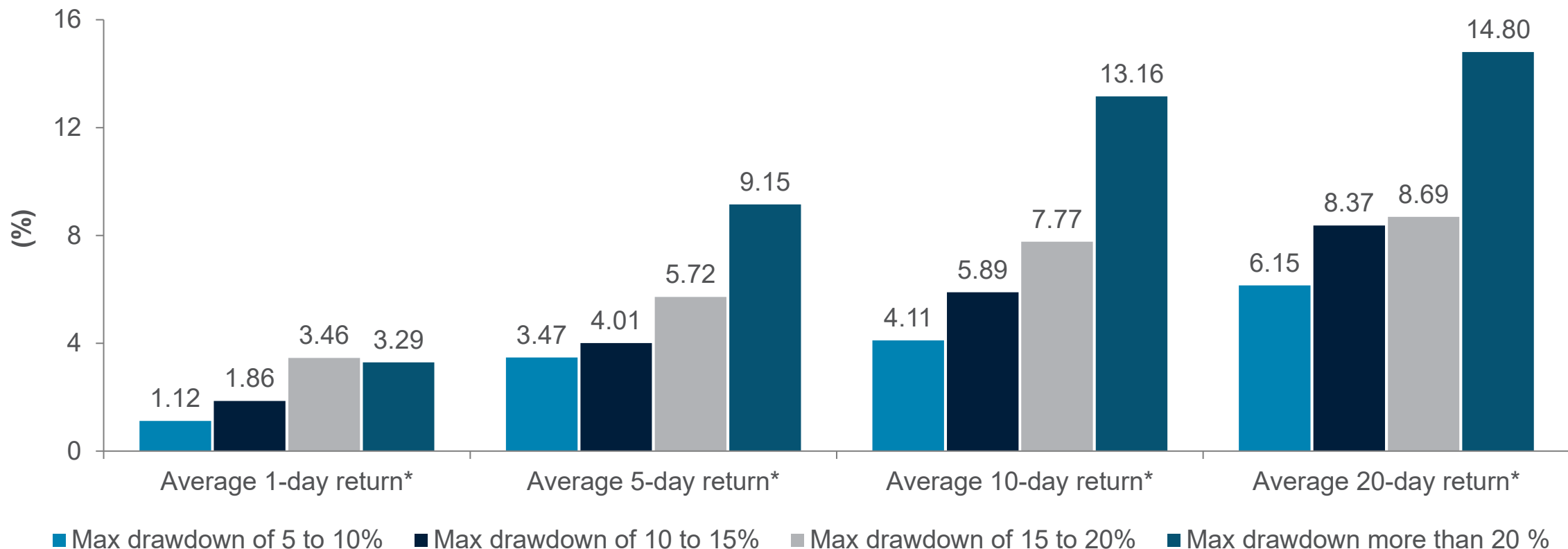
Investors should think in terms of scenarios when making investments

- Nobody knows what is going to happen in the future
- Therefore, when making investment decisions you should
 1. Consider the probability of the different scenarios
 2. Assess their impact on your financial well-being in the near-term
 3. Determine how to best take advantage of emerging conditions for your long-term success (factoring in your emotions and behavioural biases)



Fundamental concept: Time in the market matters more than timing the markets

The longer the holding period post notable drawdowns, the better the returns



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

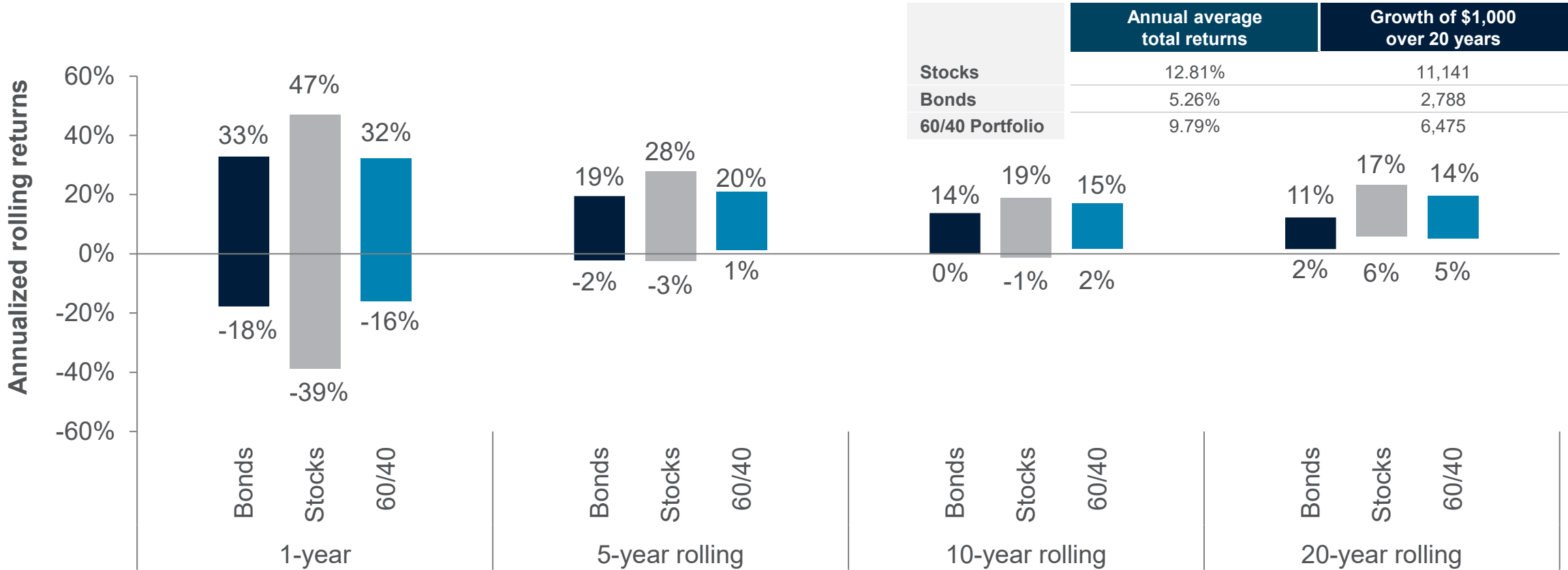
* Average subsequent trading day returns following a trough in prices, analysis since 1960



Probability of negative returns declines as the investing horizon extends

Longer horizon dampens return volatility

Range of stock, bond and blended total returns. Annualized total returns, 1950 - 2024



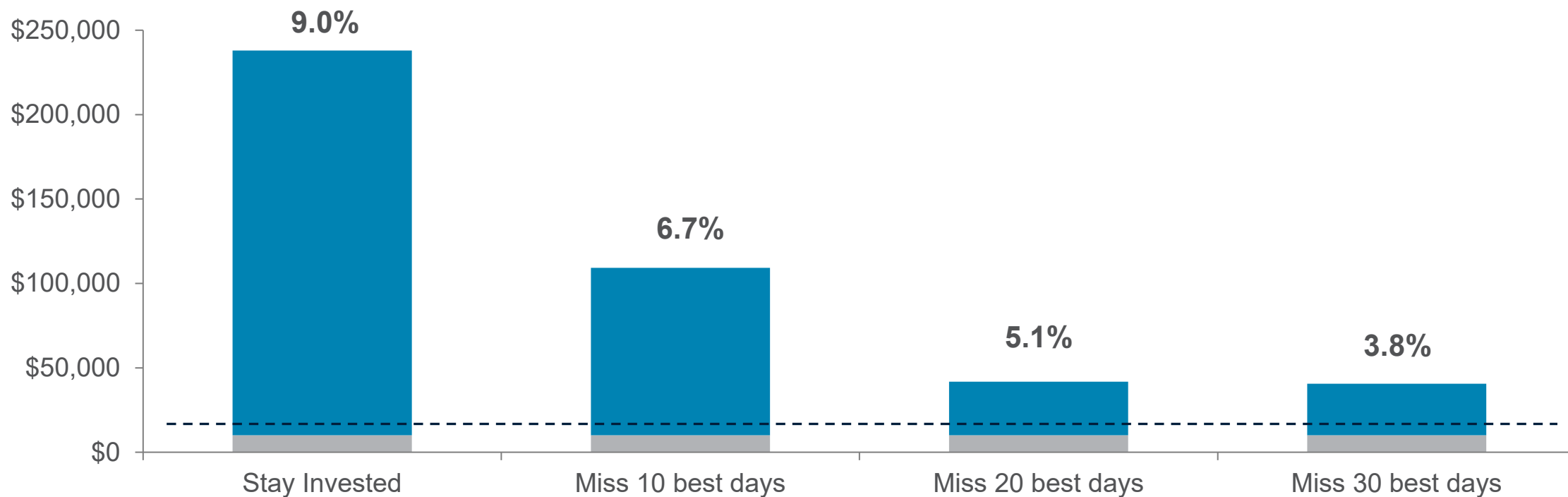
Source: Bloomberg, Robert Shiller, Standard Chartered
Returns shown are based on calendar year returns from 1950 – 2024. Stocks represented by the S&P Shiller Composite Index. Bonds represented by the US 10-year yield



The cost of missing out on markets can be very detrimental to returns

Time in the markets beats timing the markets. Historically, the worst days in equity markets have tended to be followed by its best days

S&P 500 returns and annualized returns (%) using a hypothetical USD 10,000 portfolio – total and after leaving out the best ‘up’ days*



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

* Example of S&P 500 index returns, comparing the returns of staying invested, after taking out the 10 best days, 20 best days and 30 best days of the index



What can we do to prepare for potential opportunities during a market crisis - I

“

The stock market is the only place where everything goes on sale, and no one turns up.

– Anonymous



Know yourself

- Emotions may be ones' biggest challenge during a panic/crisis. Losses are painful. Even the most seasoned investor could panic and be at a loss for what to do next
- Look to history and remember that pullbacks or bear markets tend to be short-lived and markets have continued to rise on the back of centuries of growth and technological progress



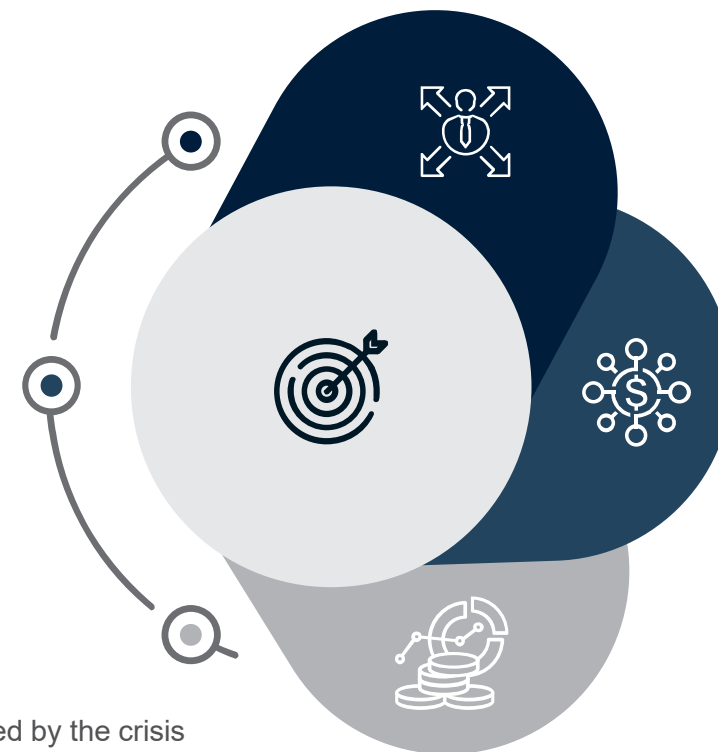
Consider your own goals in your decision-making

- Review your existing portfolio. If it is inadequate to meet your goals, consider rebalancing accordingly
- Make sure you also set aside emergency funds aside to ride through a longer-than-expected period of deteriorating market conditions



Make a plan and invest extra cash if available

- Create a shopping list of ideas to invest in
- A crisis can give investors the opportunity to:
 - **buy assets at cheaper prices**
 - **buy exposure to long term themes** that may be unduly impacted by the crisis
- Remember no one can pick the **absolute** bottom
- Start investing (**dollar cost average/lump sum**) and let your money work for you



What can we do to prepare for potential opportunities during a market crisis - II

“

An investment in knowledge pays the best interest.

– **Benjamin Franklin**



The prudent averaging-in

- A strategy where an investor spreads out the purchase of an investment into regular intervals and checks if things are going in your direction
- **Benefits:** Avoid mis-timing the market, smooths out the cost of purchases over time, offers a potential checkpoint at every interval
- **When to use:** Can be useful in a bear market. Keeps investors from potential psychological biases and takes the emotion out of investing, especially at low points of the markets
- **Risk:** May be averaging in during a prolonged slide in the markets



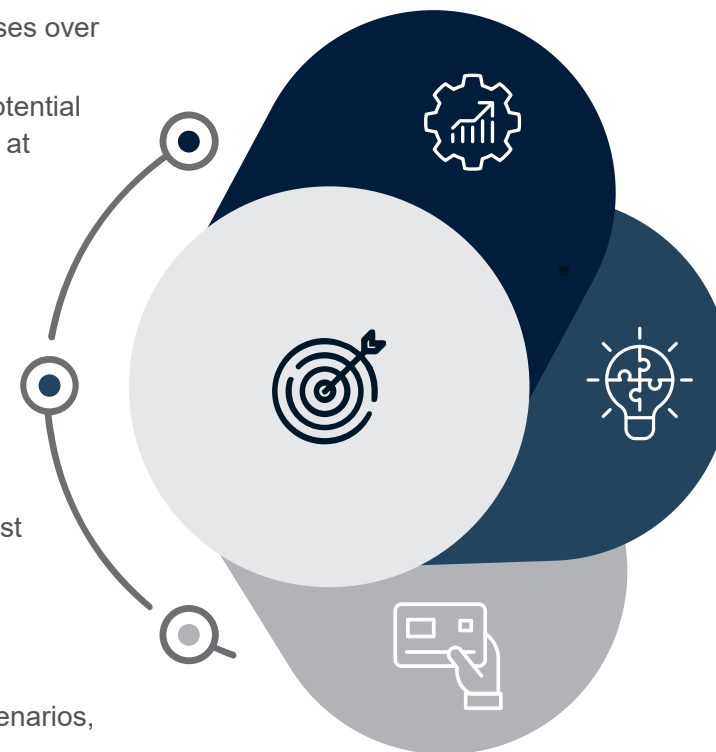
The thermostat approach

- A strategy to include **balanced diversified risk** exposure, allowing investors to quickly increase or reduce the risk of their allocation
- **Benefits:** Fast, timely response to market conditions. A smarter way to adjust risk rather than herding towards the latest fads. Helps mitigate overthinking/overanalyzing tendencies
- **When to use:** Can be used in any market conditions. Well-suited for fast moving markets, minimizing effort, complexity and time to decision
- **Risk:** May be whipsawed in choppy markets



The shopping cart

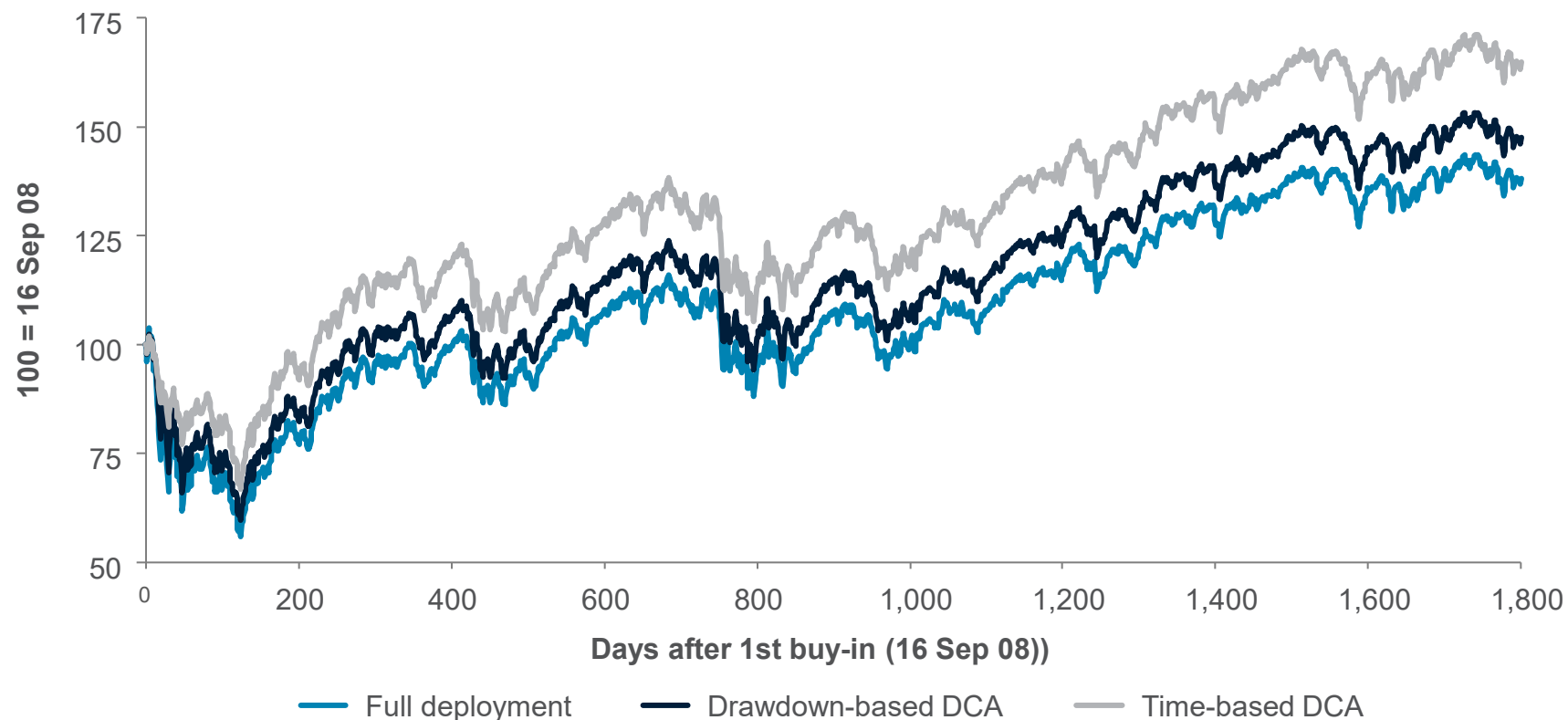
- A strategy to select asset classes which are favoured under various scenarios, if one is already well-diversified
- **Benefits:** Targeted, flexible approach to implement one's view
- **When to use:** Can be useful when one has a reasonable view on where markets are heading
- **Risk:** Views on asset classes may not pan out as expected



The “prudent” averaging-in

- Helps avoid mis-timing the market, smooths out the cost of purchases over time and offers a potential checkpoint at every interval
- A time-based dollar cost averaging (DCA) could be more superior if one believes a market decline could be prolonged
- A drawdown-based DCA could be more effective if a market decline is sharp and swift, allowing investors to capture opportunities in a more timely manner
- Having developed a DCA plan, the key to success is for investors is to keep the plan regardless of market sentiment
- **Risk:** may be averaging in during a prolonged slide in the markets

Portfolio Value



Notes:

Full deployment: An investor deploys all his/her capital at today's level of drawdown, mapped to the GFC (16 Sep 08), then simply holds. No subsequent DCA tranches

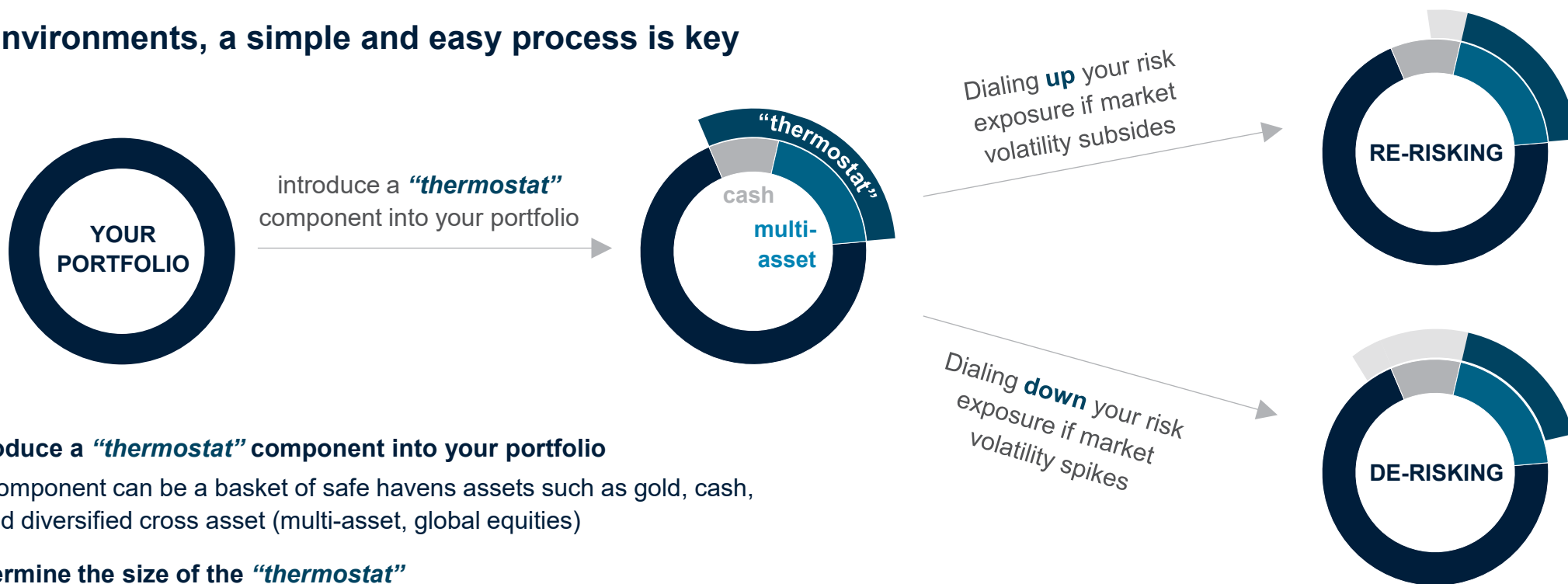
Drawdown-based: An investor deploys 50% of his/her capital at today's level of drawdown, mapped to the GFC (16 Sep 08). Every -5% lower from the current level, he/she adds 10% of his/her capital, up to 5 tranches

Time-based: An investor deploys 50% of his/her capital at today's level of drawdown, mapped to the GFC (16 Sep 08). Every 1 month onwards, he/she adds 10% of his/her capital, up to 5 tranches



The “thermostat” approach for dialing risk up or down

In volatile environments, a simple and easy process is key



Step 1 – Introduce a “thermostat” component into your portfolio

A “thermostat” component can be a basket of safe havens assets such as gold, cash, quality bonds and diversified cross asset (multi-asset, global equities)

Step 2 – Determine the size of the “thermostat”

The more concentrated your existing portfolio is in single country, single region, single sector (applicable to both bond and equity), the bigger the size of thermostat component should be

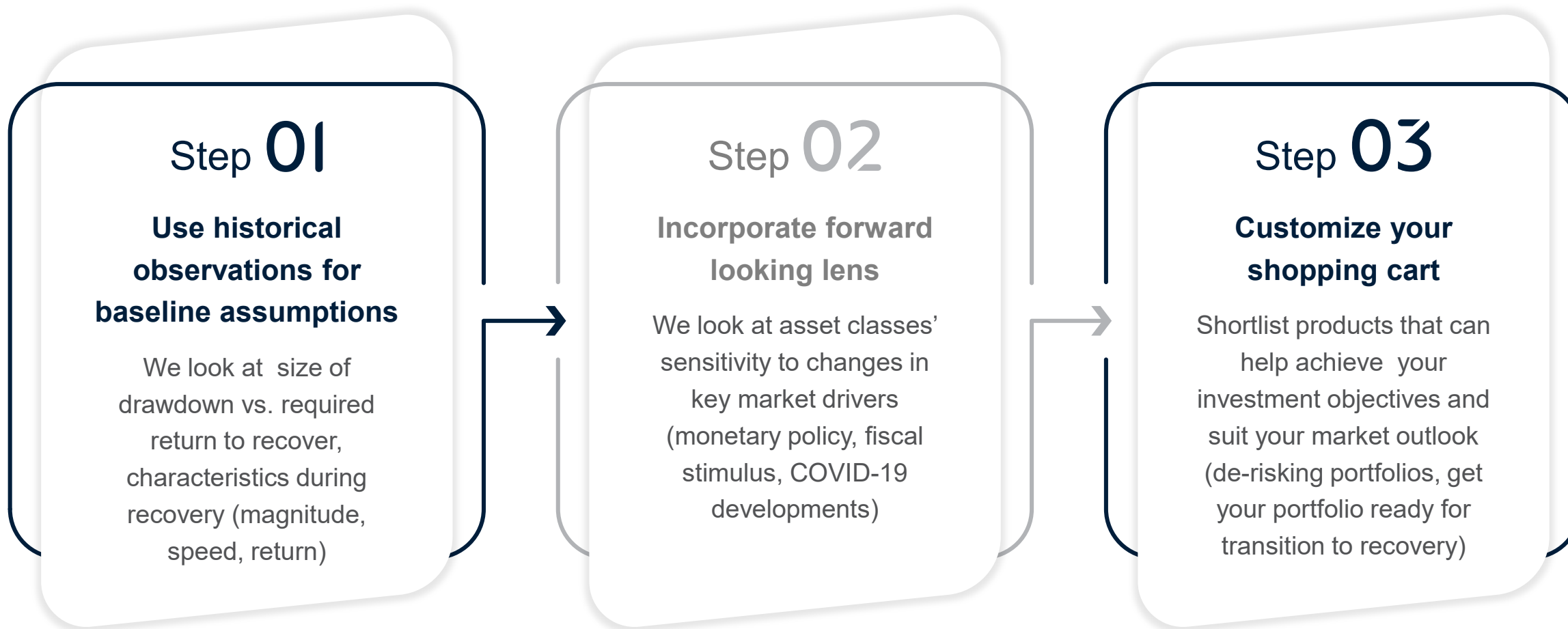
Step 3 – Adjust the “thermostat” according to market conditions

- Should market volatility subside, dial up riskiness of the thermostat by reducing safe haven assets allocation; and increasing diversified asset allocation
- Should market volatility spikes, dial down riskiness of the thermostat by increasing safe haven assets allocation; and reducing diversified asset allocation

Source: Standard Chartered



The “shopping cart” approach



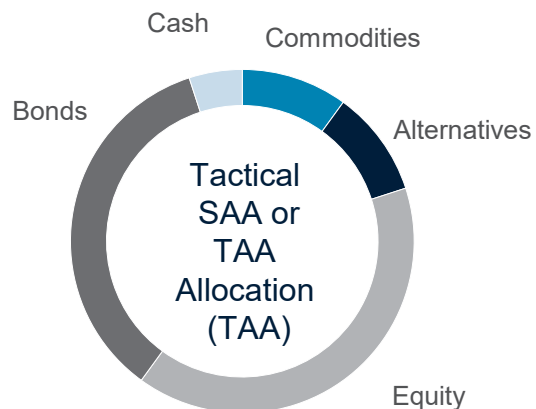
Source: Standard Chartered



Portfolio construction

Step 01 – Create your Foundation Portfolio

Create a diversified Foundation Portfolio using the SAA (for simple market access) or TAA (for house views) as a guide



Source: Standard Chartered; See latest Global Market Outlook for portfolio allocations across risk profiles

Step 02 – Add Opportunistic Overlays

Add short term (0-12 month) Opportunistic overlays if you want to add performance, enhance income, or improve portfolio diversification

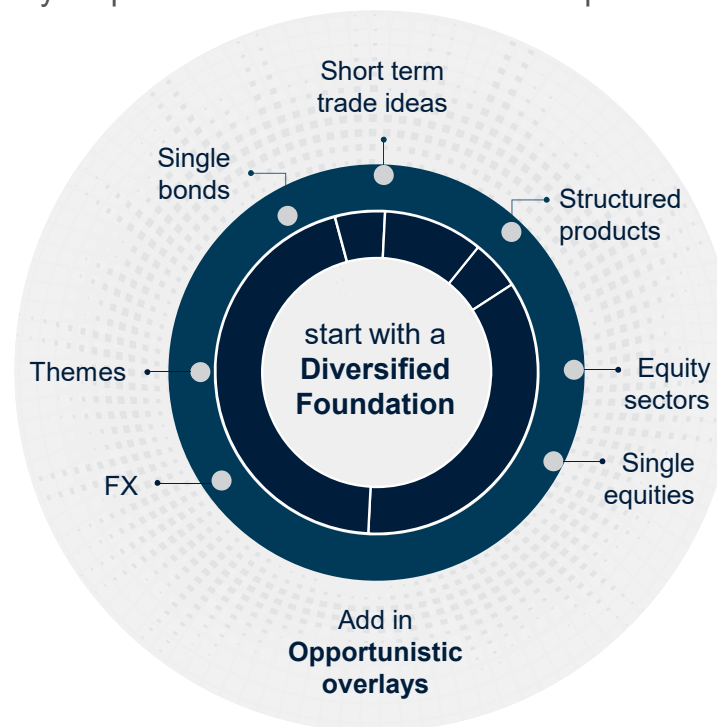
Examples of Opportunistic investments

1. Security convictions (bond / equity)
2. Equity sectors / industries
3. Themes
4. FX



Step 03 – Your Investments Portfolio

Building a diversified Foundation and then adding Opportunistic overlays that suit your preferences creates a stable and personalised portfolio



Step 04 – Your Portfolio plus Insurance

Include any Protection or Insurance needs into the portfolio



Access our views 24/7 on key platforms

SC Wealth Insights

Find out more >



YouTube >



Facebook >



LinkedIn >



SC Money Insights

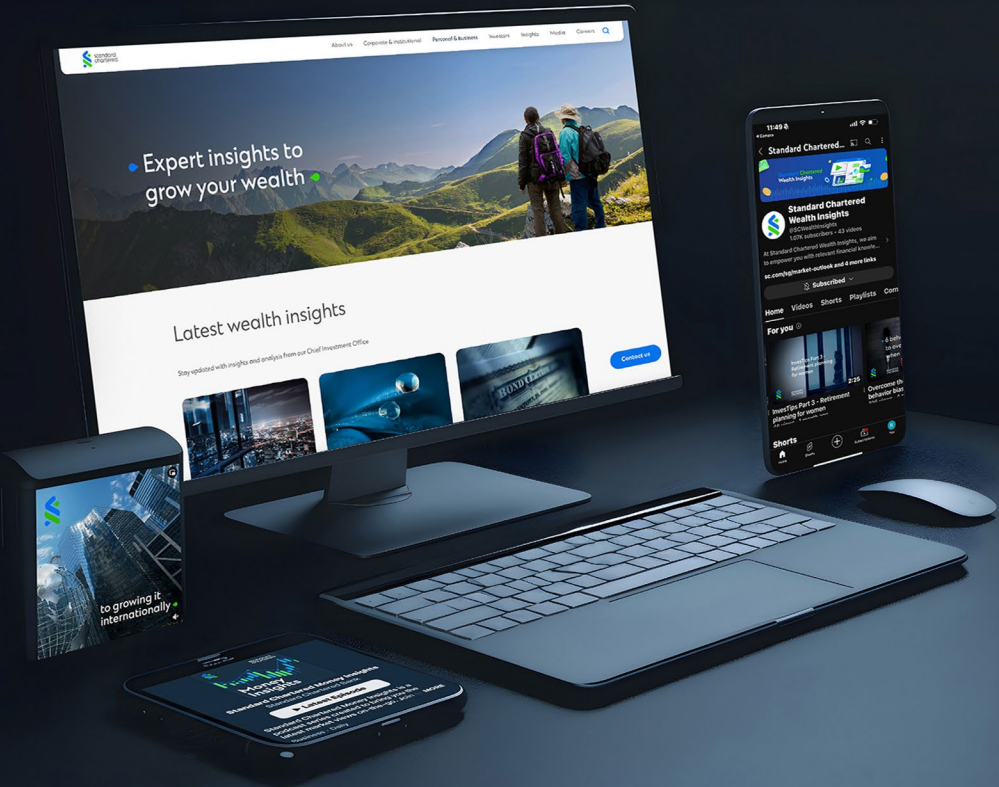
4 podcasts shows on Spotify and Apple platforms

Spotify >



Apple Podcasts >





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